Blindsided

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/56479318.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), He-Man | Adam/Teela

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), He-Man | Adam, Teela (He-Man), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Randor (He-Man), Marlena (He-Man), Perfuma (She-Ra), Huntara (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra), Horde Prime (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra), Original Characters

Additional Tags:
Adora (She-Ra) and He-Man | Adam are Siblings, Minor Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Bow Friendship (She-Ra), Catra Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Catra is Bad at Feelings (She-Ra), Catra Has Issues (She-Ra), Canon Species, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Mentioned Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Prison, Found Family, Trans Adora (She-Ra), Scorpia is a Good Friend (She-Ra), Catra & Scorpia Friendship (She-Ra), Entrapta Being Entrapta (She-Ra), Eventual Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Angst with a Happy Ending, Heavy Angst, Family Feels, Family Issues, Adora Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Adora Has Issues (She-Ra), Tags May Change, Corruption, Racism, no beta we die like Weaver

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by AstrynSerene

Summary

Catra had never had an easy life. She had grown up in the foster system after losing her fathers, gotten herself pregnant at eighteen after a drunk night at a bar, and couldn't hold a stable job that paid enough for her shitty three room apartment. She knew she wasn't built for motherhood. She had never been shown what a good parent looks like, so what made her fit to raise a child on her own? She didn't think she would be until she met Finn for the first time. Alone in a hospital bed with the tiny one month preemie kitten in her arms was enough. Finn became her everything. She would make it work somehow. She'd always made her own way, and she would find a way to give the infant the life they deserved even if it killed her.

It took three jobs, but she made enough to live in a small apartment. Then she lost two of those jobs because money went missing from the drawers and the old diner couldn't keep its doors open. Small tips at the bar and minimum wage were enough for her, but not her and a five year old. Her landlord was impatient and didn't care if Catra chose feeding Finn over paying rent.

A fight breaks out, a gun is fired.

But who would believe it was the five year old who pulled the trigger?

The Price of Freedom

Chapter Notes

Lord help me I'm posting another AU.

The sound of bars screaming against the concrete as they slid open or closed was nothing new. It had been her everyday for ten years. The only difference this time is people she actually cared about stood on the other side. Well, two of them anyway. No offense to her parole officer, but forgive her for having a hard time keeping a bleeding heart for her. She took a deep breath, her hand sweating as she gripped the strap of her duffel bag, taking her first steps back into the real world. No more breakout fights at seven in the morning because someone stole another inmates cigarettes, no more random searches that left her cleaning up her tiny space for the next two days, or having to literally beat some asshole who messed with her few things thinking she had something. She didn't have anything that was valuable, at least to anyone else. To her, the most priceless thing she owned was a single photo of *them*. Finn. When they were three, playing with the two stuffed animals she had been able to buy them after saving any spare change for months, a bright smile on their face as they showed them off to the camera. She had beaten a few inmates into unconsciousness before that mocked her or who had dared to try and take the photo from her. She figured she should be proud of the reputation she had built in the Brightmoon Women's Correction Center over the last ten years; nobody dared to touch anything she said was hers, or even looked at her funny by the time she was released. They knew they would wind up in the infirmary if they did, that they risked worse if they even mentioned her child's name in the wrong tone.

"Wildcat!"

She shook her head. That was behind her now. She was- free. Free as a convicted killer could be she supposed. She didn't think she would ever feel truly free until she day she died. She looked

up, offering a wave with her free hand as she stepped up to her waiting friends.

“You got everything? Release forms, identification papers, anything personal?” Huntara asked, making Catra want to roll her eyes. But she held back. She knew it was something that had to be asked.

“Yeah, I got it all.” She replied simply, tightening the hold on the strap.

“Make sure you read that release form and any other papers given to you. That’s how you stay out of here.”

“I know.”

“Alright then.” Huntara nodded to them, opening the door for the trio to make their way out to Scorpia’s truck, “Remember. Every Wednesday at four, I’ll call you on Tuesdays to decide the location.”

“Thank you.” Catra sighed, running her fingers through her hair as she followed Scorpia and Entrapta out to the parking lot. It had been so long since she’d seen the world without being behind a fifteen foot fence, been in a car, or allowed to leave her cell block without being cuffed. It was- different. Good. Maybe.

“I cannot tell you how excited I’ve been for today, I could barely sleep! We made sure to prep your room for you and have everything ready for you!” Scorpia rambled as they all slid into the car. Entrapta sat behind the passenger seat while Scorpia and Catra got into the front.

“I’m convinced Scorpia did not get the required hours of sleep last night due to her inflated excitement of your release.” Entrapta commented, buckling in as the vehicle roared to life, “It doesn’t seem like you share the same amount of enthusiasm.” She added when Catra didn’t answer.

"It's… surreal, I guess. I dunno, Entrapta." Catra sighed, leaning against the window, watching the view of the prison slowly shrink and fade behind her as they left the parking lot and started down the road back to the city limits of Brightmoon, "I don't see things getting any better, all things considered."

"Sure they will! You have a job already, a place to stay, and Entrapta is in contact with a therapist for you! We'll get you back on track in no time!"

"At least bar tending is something I know how to do well.." Catra feigned a small smile. It was the last job she had before everything went wrong. Before the world decided she didn't deserve happiness. Since that woman decided she didn't deserve happiness, "I guess at least I'll earn more than prison credit for work now."

Scorpia bit her lip, but said nothing about the last comment, "You aren't alone, Catra. We're both here for you and anything, *anything* you need, we gotcha!"

"Yeah…" Catra knew that much was true- to an extent. What she wanted, really wanted, she knew she would never have. That was probably for the best anyway, she didn't want to mess up whatever life they were given by showing her face. They would have been too young to remember her anyway. She liked to imagine they had the letters she'd sent over the years, but she knew deep down that whatever family had taken them in would never let their child see letters sent to them by a murderer.

As far as the world was concerned, as soon as the cuffs went on, she lost any right to call Finn her child.

⚔

Settling in to the apartment had been easy. Her room wasn't much bigger than her cell, the only difference being she didn't have to share the space with another person. It was- nice, cozy in a way; it gave her a sense of normality. Scorpia and Entrapta had

filled the small closet with a handful of outfits for her, painted the walls her favorite shade of blue, gotten her a brand new bed set, and placed a bulletin board above the small desk in the corner with photos of them all together, of Finn, of the picture perfect past that she wished was reality. It had brought her to tears, the kindness her friends still showed her- despite everything. How hard they were trying, when it should be *her* trying to prove her worth to stay there to *them*. She would find a way to repay them one day for their generosity, even if they never asked for it. She knew the moment word got out about what she had done, her friends would face backlash for even associating with her. Maybe when that happened they would come to their senses and throw her out onto the streets where she belonged, move on to something important and put their past behind them, something she knew she would never be able to do.

She didn't sleep the first two nights.

The lack of sleep didn't show until day three, during their shift at The Crimson Waste, when Catra's agitation towards a particular patron had her glaring daggers and digging a grove into the bar with her claws.

"Wildcat?"

"*What*-?" The brunette snapped, pausing when Scorpia stopped, taking a step back. She sighed, "Sorry… just…"

"On edge, I understand. Are you not sleeping?"

Catra shrugged, grabbing a towel and distracting her hands by cleaning the bar, "As much as I can."

"If you need to, you can go lay down in the staff room for a while. Even if you don't sleep, you could at least try and rest."

"I don't need to get fired week one, and the last thing I need is to be alone with my thoughts."

“You won’t be fired. The owners are good friends of mine, and like I told you before, they know the situation, and understand you need time.”

“That’s nice of them, but I’m fine. I just.. I can’t lay there being useless.”

“Well, you can also go help out in the kitchen if it’s the… customers.” She added, voice a bit lower. She knew Catra could easily hear even over the loud music and drunks shouting at the TV.

Sighing, Catra nodded, throwing her towel over her shoulder, “Yeah that’s- probably smart. Thanks.” She turned around and made her way to the kitchen, not surprised to see the owners, one at the grill and the other talking to their partners.

“Hey, Catra. Everything okay?” Lonnie asked, concern removing her smile as she turned her attention from her boyfriends to her employee.

“Yeah, fine. Just, asshole drunks. Scorpia said you might need a hand back here?”

“No problem! Rogelio has the grill covered I think, but Kyle and I were about to start taking stock of things since the night’s ending. You can help if you want- this doofus has never been good with numbers.” She teased, lightly punching Kyle’s shoulder, making the blonde laugh nervously.

“Math’s never been my- strong suite.” He cleared his throat, “So an extra, smarter, hand would be great!”

Nodding, Catra gently took the offered clipboard from Lonnie, the three walking into the back pantry to start while Rogelio finished the last few food orders for the night.

“How are things…holding up?”

Catra said nothing at first, despite expecting a question like that. She couldn’t blame them for asking, she would probably do the same thing in their shoes, “Fine, I guess. I’m surviving. Entrapta and Scorpia’s generosity gives me a bed.”

“Well, if you ever need anything, or someone aside from them to talk to, you’re more than welcome to come to any of us, okay?” Lonnie offered a smile, a genuine smile that made Catra’s heart ache.

“Thanks…” She whispered, trying to focus her attention on the job at hand so her emotions didn’t break the wall around her heart. She couldn’t let that wall break, no matter what. If she let her emotions bubble back up, there was no way she would last a month without her child. She had worked too hard to build it over the last ten years to let small acts of kindness tear it down now.

~

Aside from occasional outbursts, the first week passed without much incident. Easy parole meeting at the park, mostly calm shifts. Catra was less than surprised that the cliff hanging peace didn't last. She couldn't help herself, and she looked into where Finn was, and they were in *Brightmoon*. They were not even in a different city, they were less than two hours away from her somewhere, and she had a chance to *find* them again.

She knew she shouldn’t, she should leave them alone, let them live their life without their fucked up mother that didn’t deserve to see them ever again. That didn’t deserve the title of being called their mother.

She just wanted to know they were okay. She wanted to know that they were having a good life, the life they deserved.

“Wildcat?” Scorpia bit her lip, gently pushing open the door, her heart breaking when she saw what was open on her friend’s laptop and said friend curled up against her bed with tears streaming down her face, “Catra…” Scorpia slowly approached,

carefully lowering herself to sit next to her friend. She was surprised when the brunette practically launched herself into her arms, though she was more than happy to wrap her in a much needed hug, "Shh… It's okay… I've gotcha…"

"I j-just want…"

"I know… If they live in Brightmoon, we can find them maybe..?"

"Their p-parents w-would never let a *murderer* see their c-child! T-They won't r-remember me a-anyway! And if they do there's n-no telling what they've been told about me!"

Scorpia sighed. She didn't know what to say, because Catra could be wrong, but could also be right. It all depended on the family that had Finn. She gently ran her pincer over her friend's back, "We'll figure it out, Catra… Somehow."

⚔

Finn knew a lot of things about his mom. She was loud, goofy, emotional, and cared way too much about the people around her. What she wasn't, was quiet. Things had been normal last night. They'd eaten dinner at Sweet Bee's Bistro with Uncle Adam and Aunt Teela, mom had helped them with their homework when they got home, and they watched the new episode of Masters of the Universe before bed.

But then Finn woke to their second alarm, which was *weird*. If they weren't up after the first their mom *always* woke them up with the promise of breakfast. That didn't happen that morning. After getting dressed, they had found their mom staring blankly at her phone, being startled at their sudden appearance and closing whatever app she'd had open like she'd been caught with secret information from Area 51.

When questioned, Adora had promised them she was fine, that it was just a rough morning, that it would be fine and not to worry about it, and had then proceeded their morning routine like

nothing had happened. Like she wasn't hiding something. They had breakfast, Adora had drove them to school, and now they were walking out of the Mystacor Family Clinic together, Adora from her monthly check in to refill her hormone therapy shots and Finn getting their hearing checked, only to be told what they already knew was happening.

They still didn't know what had caused it, their family had never told them. They knew they had been adopted, and they knew that everyone around them knew what they didn't: how the scar on their cheek came to be and what caused them to lose most of their hearing in their left ear. Any memories behind their sixth birthday were fuzzy, or not there at all. They wished they knew, if not for anything else, to help them cope with their impeding deafness. They wanted so desperately to know who was behind the faceless visions and dreams that somehow felt like home.

"We can get you fitted for a hearing aid if you want." Adora finally spoke up when they got into Swifty, the trusty red pickup truck Adora had gotten for her sixteenth birthday, and had kept up and refused to replace ever since. Finn had named it not long after they had been adopted, and the name had stuck with everyone ever since.

"I still have forty five percent hearing left, we can wait a little longer. I- I'm not ready for that yet." Finn slowly admitted, not making eye contact as they stared out the window.

"Okay, whatever you need, kiddo." Adora smiled, taking a deep breath as she put the truck into drive, starting the way down to the pharmacy. She never understood why the pharmacy and the clinic couldn't be in the same building. At least it was on the way home, "Do you wanna stop by the sushi bar for dinner?"

At least that hadn't changed with their mother's strange change in behavior. Anytime they got bad news at the clinic, got a good grade on a hard test, or even just because, they would get rewarded or gifted a trip to the Seaworthy Buffet, a chain sushi bar that had started in Salineas. It had always been Finn's favorite

special place to eat. Slowly, they nodded, “That would be great, thanks.”

“Of course, Finn…”

Silence took over the car ride, separating the two all the way through the trip to the pharmacy, even with the strangely attentive pharmacist and getting their first plates at Seaworthy, but they both knew what it was about.

“I’m sorry…”

“Then why don’t you tell me?” Finn glared, tightening their grip on their chopsticks.

“Finn… It’s- complicated, I just don’t think-“

“Why NOT?”

Adora flinched, casting apologetic looks to surrounding tables before returning her attention to Finn, who’s expression made it clear they already regretted shouting.

“I’m sorry, mom…”

“It’s okay, you have- every right to feel this way and want- need to know. I want to tell you, I really do, but it’s… it’s a very adult situation and- difficult for even me to understand it all. Please, trust me to tell you things when the time is right?”

Finn sighed, ears pinning as they slowly nodded, “Okay…”

“Thank you, Finn.” Adora offered a sad smile as she reached over and brushed Finn’s bangs out of their face, “I love you.”

“I love you too, mom.” Finn smiled, taking a deep breath to calm down as they returned their attention to dinner. They trusted their mom, they would tell them eventually.

They just hoped that ‘eventually’ would be soon.

Grief

Chapter Summary

Everyone wants what is best for Finn, but not everyone is on a timer.

Chapter Notes

If you don't cry your eyes out the way I did writing this then you have no soul :)

TW// Depression, Death mention

CW// Racism, Corruption

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"I don't know what to do! I knew she would reach out *eventually* , but I didn't think it would be *this* fast! It feels wrong to say yes but it also feels wrong to say no! They're her kid, too!" Adora had been rambling for the past ten minutes, but neither Bow or Glimmer wanted to interrupt her. They wanted to let her get it out of her system, even if that meant listening to her repeat herself.

Adora had been a hot mess the entire day. She had called Bow to sub in for her class after getting off the phone with Mara, Finn's social worker. She'd then spent the next few hours spiraling into a panic in Glimmer's office until Bow showed up.

"Did you come here for my opinion on this, or did you just need a Best Friend Squad vent session?" Glimmer asked once Adora seemed to be done talking. She leaned against her desk, interlacing her fingers together.

"…It would be nice to know what you think, yes." Adora pouted, plopping herself down on the couch next to Bow.

"Personally? I wouldn't let Finn within a thousand feet of that woman. Finn has no memory of her, and let's not forget she's a convicted killer, and obviously not mentally sound. If you accept just letting them meet her, you're looking at her going after visitation next, and then what if she tries to get custody of them?"

"She can… do that?" Adora's eyes widened slightly. She hadn't thought about that even being a possibility.

"Well she never forfeit her rights as their parent. Technically, whether a judge is likely to grant it or not, there is nothing stopping her from trying. And I know you don't want to put Finn through that."

"Of course I don't…but…" Adora looked away, flinching when Bow rested his hand on her shoulder.

"But?"

She sighed, biting her lip as she looked back up to her friends, "But… But if I were in her position, I- I can't even *imagine* the pain she's going through and how much she has to miss them."

Glimmer shrugged, “That’s the price you pay when you literally murder someone, Adora. You give up your right to a normal life- the right to walk among society and share the world the way everyone else does.”

“That doesn’t mean she doesn’t have emotions, Glimmer.” Bow pointed out, “You can’t act like you wouldn’t fight tooth and nail to get Estelle and Galaxy back if someone took them from us.”

“I also didn’t murder anyone, Bow. So I don’t have to worry about social services taking the twins from us to begin with.” The pinkette crossed her arms, leaning back in her chair, “All I’m saying is this woman made her choice, and now she has to live with them, and you should consider *your* child before a stranger who also happens to be a murderer.”

Adora sighed, running her fingers through her hair, letting the long blonde waves cascade over her shoulders, “I *am* , Glimmer. Finn is my entire world and I will put them before anything and anyone else every single time.”

Glimmer furrowed her eyebrows, “So *why* are you even thinking twice about this?”

“Because I know how badly Finn wants to know about their past,” Adora leaned forward, resting her forearms against her legs, “The countless times they’ve begged me to tell them everything. Because I’ve read the hundreds- probably thousand letters that she’s sent them over the last decade, I have them all safely packed away that I’ve *always* planned to give Finn one day. I

know *I'm* not- prepared, yet, to tell them. I thought I would have more time, that I would be able to wait until they turned eighteen to tell them everything."

"And your plan isn't working out the way you planned. That tracks."

Adora glared at Bow, who held up his hands in defense.

"Sorry! Just- that kinda happens to us a lot, when it comes to planning things. Adam doesn't call us the Improve Squad for nothing."

"Well, the plans that fall apart aren't usually this life changing in importance." The blonde huffed, lower lip pouting slightly as she leaned back against the couch again, "I think I should accept-"

"-Adora you *cannot* be serious!"

"Let me finish." Adora snapped, "I think I should accept the meeting, and go myself. I won't bring Finn. I'll meet with her myself and decide whether or not I think I should let her meet them."

"..I really think you should take more time to think on this, Adora. Even you meeting her is opening the door for her."

Adora furrowed her eyebrows, “I appreciate the concern, Glimmer. I know you only want what’s best for Finn, but so do I. I’ll talk to you two after I meet with her, and we’ll go from there, okay? Trust me?”

Glimmer stayed silent for a few beats before sighing, giving a small nod, “Of course I trust you, Adora…” Getting to her feet, she rounded her desk to sit between her best friend and her husband, “Just- wait a day or two to reply at least, okay? Make it clear she has to work for it, make her intentions known and clear. Make sure she knows you’re in control.”

A small smile formed, and Adora nodded, before hugging the shorter woman close to her, “Okay, I will.”

“Good. If that’s settled, you should get your butt to the school before Finn’s practice ends.”

The blonde’s eyes widened, “Shit! What time is it?!” She pulled out of the embrace to check her watch, “It’s already four thirty!?” She groaned, getting to her feet and grabbing her bag as Bow offered it to her, “Thanks for the talk guys, I’ll text you later!” She exclaimed, rushing out goodbyes as she hurried out of Glimmer’s office.

⚔

Catra sighed, throwing her phone onto the bed as she shrugged her jacket off onto the floor before collapsing on her bed, hugging her pillow as she curled up, trying to take up as little space as possible. Why had she let Scorpia convince her to reach out to social services? The second she had said her name the entire conversation had changed. The woman on the phone -Mara- had made it painfully clear that it was completely up to Finn's family whether or not she was allowed to see them, and that she would be lucky to get a response at all. She had never said it, but her cold tone was louder than anything she *had* said.

You don't deserve to make this request.

She knew before she hung up- she wasn't going to get a response. Finn's parents would probably laugh with the social worker when they got the call, then scoff at the absurdity that she would even dare to reach out at all. The tone had told her everything. Finn had never been given her letters. Social services were obligated to send them, but the family didn't have to let Finn have them, read them, know they existed. That she existed. Why would they? Finn had everything they needed, and that didn't include her. Why would it? What she needed didn't matter to them, or anyone else. It hadn't since that gun had gone off, since she was tossed to the ground and cuffed, locked in a cell and put through a trial that had torn her to pieces over and over again. She hadn't even been interrogated. She'd been given a piece of paper and told to write her confession- and she had. What other options did she have? They wouldn't have accepted anything else.

And yet- they tore her apart on the stand anyway, because she deserved it. Her heart had been ripped out and put on display, her reasoning didn't matter, what had happened *before* the shot didn't matter, no matter how desperately she tried to explain. Nobody

had listened. It wasn't like her lawyer had tried very hard either. They had been a public defender, not like she could afford anything else. She barely remembered her name. Octavia? Whatever. She hadn't tried, not really. Her "best advice" had been to take a plea deal, which hadn't been any better than what she got. The only thing that had mattered in that trial had been that a woman had been shot, a woman that had been a monster, and that Catra felt zero remorse for. That woman had made her life a living nightmare. She reminded her every day that she was lucky to have a home at all, that she was being generous.

Catra knew the truth- the woman had money, and Catra didn't. That woman was a human, and Catra was a magicat. Brightmoon was supposed to be one of the most diverse and accepting places on Etheria, but Catra knew better. People like her were ignored, tossed aside, and used as "examples" to the public. It didn't matter what the truth was, because they had someone to blame who couldn't prove anything else as fact. The world wasn't kind to those without power.

Tears ran down her face as she tried to make herself smaller, tried to pretend that her heart wasn't actively shattering into a million pieces. That the wall she had worked so hard to create had been demolished in minutes. She should have known better. She *did* know better, but she had tried anyway. She had tried a fruitless reach that would do nothing but slam the nail in the coffin. Her coffin. She hadn't stood a chance. A murderer, a magicat, a waste of space trying to reach for a single good thing? Why did she even try? Why did she let any hope into her heart that she would be granted even a glance into her child's life? Who cared that Finn was all that kept her tethered to the ground? It wasn't like she had anything else! A mate? Please, who would want something like her? A family? Gone before she turned ten. Motherhood was *all* she had. It had been the only thing to push her through the

past ten years, and now she knew, she *knew* it was gone. All she had left was a broken heart fallen into the pit of-

Catra's tail stilled. Her ears pinned. It felt like everything had just-stopped. The world kept spinning, but *her* world had stopped. She had failed. She had failed Finn. She had failed herself. She couldn't stop the one thing she had been fighting so hard to prevent in the slim, one in a million shot she had at a second chance. But now it was too late.

She was Grieving.

⚔

"You're five minutes late." Finn teased as they slid into the passenger seat, tossing their duffel bag into the backseat of the truck.

"Sorry, kiddo. It's been a-"

"-Rough day?"

Adora bit her lip, "..I've been saying that a lot, huh?" Her shoulders slumped slightly when the teenager nodded, "Sorry…"

“Whatever. It’s- fine.” Finn sighed, buckling in before crossing their arms loosely, “I raided your snack drawer with the twins.” They feigned a smirk. If their mom wasn’t going to tell them anything, what was the point in trying to ask anymore?

“Again? Seriously Finn?” Adora chuckled, “Does Bow know?”

“Who do you think gave me the key?”

Groaning, Adora rolled her eyes playfully, “Well, then you all can explain to the class why they have to wait until next week for me to restock it.”

“Moomm!”

“Don’t ‘mom’ me.” Adora smirked, “Now, do you have homework?”

Finn shook their head, “Nah, finished it during Homeroom.”

“I’m proud of you.” She cast them a smile after stopping at a light, “Do you have room to think about what you want for dinner?”

“Pizza?”

Adora laughed, “Alright, sounds like a plan.”

“Yes!”

Smiling, Adora continued the drive towards their home. She’d managed to put the day’s events behind her for the time being. She could call Mara in a day or two, worry about this meeting in a day or two. Right now, Finn was her priority, and she would do everything she could to keep them happy and safe.

⚔

“She’s Grieving.”

“What exactly is that..?” Scorpia frowned, “I know what the word means but- I’m guessing with the way you said that it means something different -worse- for magicats?”

Slowly, the scientist nodded, “It’s- it’s a state of depression, worse than anything you or I could ever experience. The most common form is over their mate. If they pass away or- if a magicat is with a non-magicat that ends the relationship, anything like that can send them into Grieving. In this case though- it’s a sub-form called Parental Grieving. It’s a lot more rare, but for someone like Catra…” Entrapta sighed, hugging herself as she leaned against her friend’s door frame.

“So what can we do for her?”

“We need to keep a close eye on her, make sure she eats- I don’t think she needs to be alone any longer than an hour.”

Nodding, Scorpia glanced into the room. Catra was curled up, ears pinned and tail deathly still. She had been in the same position for over a day now. She hadn’t spoken, hadn’t eaten, hadn’t slept as far as the others knew.

They dedicated the next forty eight hours to Catra, watching over her, trying to coax her to do anything. It worked, for a very short amount of time, but they managed to get her to drink some tea and got her to speak once. It wasn’t much, she simply had said “I’m sorry” and nothing else. It became clear in the following days that despite their best efforts, Catra was only getting worse.

Scorpia was worried. Entrapta was worried. They knew about Grieving, more now thanks to the extra emergency research they had been doing. Catra had talked about it happening to one of her fathers. The signs were clear, smacking them in the face.

The only problem is- it wasn't curable. At least that's what all the research told them. All they could do was... be there. Give her company. Make sure she wasn't alone.

Scorpia wiped her eyes, sharing a look with Entrapta before pushing the door open. Entrapta stepped in first, holding a tray

with a cup of tea and bowl of soup.

"Wildcat..?"

Catra didn't answer. Didn't move. Didn't acknowledge she had even heard them, "We know you don't have an appetite, but it would be good for you to eat anyway..." Entrapta spoke softly, gently setting the tray on the nightstand before they both took a seat on the bed.

Scorpia carefully wrapped her arms around Catra, lifting her into her arms and cradling her against her chest, "You need to eat something... or- 0r drink some tea at least..!"

"I know you hate needles... I don't want to have to give you an IV..." Entrapta muttered, blinking away tears of her own.

Catra said nothing. She stared ahead, body slumped against Scorpia. They knew she could hear them, but doubted she was really listening. She was pale, sweaty, Entrapta was fairly certain her friend was running a fever. Her theory was confirmed when she gently brushed Catra's bangs out of her face, "It's getting worse..." She whispered, looking up at Scorpia, who had already teared up again, "We have to do something soon... She- she's shutting down, I don't think she can eat on her own anymore.."

"Would the IV help..?"

Entrapta avoided eye contact. She slid her hand down Catra's cheek, moving down her arm and taking her hand. Tears rolled down her cheeks, "Temporarily."

"Temp..." Scorpia's eyes widened, "Entrapta..."

"... Don't make me say it, Scorpia. Please."

They both looked at Catra, who had closed her eyes. She looked like she was sleeping, but neither could say for sure, "I'm- I'm so sorry, Catra..." Scorpia whispered, reality setting in that she would probably be planning one of her best friend's funerals in the coming weeks, and there was nothing she could do about it.

"I can.. I can get the IV drip in here... It should give us... a few extra days. If we're l-lucky.." Entrapta cut herself off with a sob, squeezing Catra's hand. It was a surprise to Scorpia, who had never seen the scientist so- emotional. But the three of them had always been close friends, a trio of outcasts that had little, but had each other. Now they were being ripped apart with nothing they could do to help. No matter how badly they wanted to help their best friend, the friend that had done so much for them over the years, that had been through more than anyone should have to suffer through in one lifetime, nothing they could do would be enough.

Scorpia nodded slowly, but before Entrapta could get up, Catra's phone started to ring. The girls glanced over, "Social Services"

staring back at them as it flashed across the screen. They shared looks of hope, looks of terror, the answer from that phone call would be the final seal in Catra's future, that they were certain of.

Slowly, Entrapta reached forward, taking a few deep breaths as she picked up the phone and answered the call, putting it on speaker, "Hello..?"

" *This is Mara from Mystacor Social Services. Is this Catra Dr'iluth?* "

"This is Entrapta. I'm- I'm Catra's sister."

" *.. Alright. Well, let her know that Finn's mother, Adora Grayskull, has agreed to meet with her in two days at the Brightmoon Law Firm. The meeting is scheduled for four pm.* "

The girls shared looks of shock, joy, fear of it being too late, before the scientist shook her head, "T-Thank you! She will be there!"

" *Good. Make sure she isn't late.* "

Entrapta felt rage bubble up when the line dropped before she could reply. Whatever. Screw you too, lady. She looked back to Catra, cupping her cheek, "Catra...?"

"Wildcat..?" Scorpia sniffed, securing her hold on the brunette, "You did it, Wildcat..."

Catra opened her eyes, slowly, but she still stared straight ahead. Still, it was something !

"You have a meeting on Thursday... There's a chance still... Don't- please, please don't give up now..."

Anyone else would have missed it, but Scorpia and Entrapta were too in tune with Catra and how she worked. Her eyes dilated. Barley. But it was a sign. The sign, that they needed.

She heard them.

She was there .

Chapter End Notes

:)

Meeting

Chapter Summary

> Secrets always find their way out- especially when they're written down.

Chapter Notes

> Okayy, so here is some information about the lore and background of the AU to answer some questions I was seeing in the comments.
>
> Grieving is something I adopted from a different fic that I read years ago. I think it gives a good visual to what depression can do to a person, and it fits well with my Magicat Lore surrounding the connections they share with those around them.
>
> I noticed a lot of hate for Glimmer because of her current opinions, and I can't blame you, but also remember that she has never met Catra, read the letters, and her only knowledge of the trial is the public information released that was written by Horde Prime (the prosecution lawyer for the trial).

“There you go… you’re doing great, Wildcat…” Scorpia encouraged, smiling warmly at her friend as she helped her sit up against the three pillows Entrapta had set up for her. The two had taken the rest of the week off work, and had dedicated all of their time to Catra. The progress she’d made over the last twelve hours had been astounding. She had broken her fever by midnight, her tail had managed to wrap around Entrapta’s leg, and with Scorpia holding a cup of tea, she had been able to sip on it through a straw. She still hadn’t spoken yet, but she wasn’t actively dying in their arms.

None of them had slept, and it would probably put them all on edge during the meeting the following afternoon, but it would be worth it. It had to be worth it. Entrapta had done more research from Catra's bedside. Despite there never being a recorded 'cure' to Grieving, there been Pauses, as it was put, and that matched what they were witnessing with Catra.

"Do you think she'll be able to talk or- or walk in time?" Scorpia asked, drawing Entrapta's gaze from her phone screen. She continued to gently caress Catra's hair with her free hand as she spoke.

"I think so. We're going with her, so if she does need anything, we'll be there."

"Are we allowed to go? The social worker did say *Catra* had a meeting…"

Entrapta shrugged, "I don't like her. We're going."

Unable to stop the laugh that followed, Scorpia nodded, "Yeah, I agree." It didn't need to be said, they both knew that opinions of them were mixed just because they were close to Catra. They didn't care, they never had. They had both dealt with backhanded comments and rude glances even before Catra was released from prison. They had both agreed to never tell her about it though. She had enough negative views about herself already.

"I- I really, really hope Finn's.. current guardian is nice, and gives us a chance to explain things without a fight…"

"Me too. I think they will, I don't see why they would have accepted the meeting otherwise."

Nodding, Entrapta returned her attention to Catra, who was staring at her hands. She placed her hand next to the brunette's tears welling up in her eyes when she actually took and squeezed hers in return. It was light, but it was there, "We're gonna do everything we can to make sure you see Finn again."

Catra gave Entrapta's hand another gentle squeeze, blinking slowly before closing her eyes entirely. They knew she was tired, she needed as much rest as she could get, "Don't worry, Wildcat. We'll make sure you're there in time."

Though she didn't respond vocally, she did give off a tiny trill, and that was the best thing her friends had heard in days.

⚔

Finn was frustrated. That was one word for it. They had always trusted their mom, their family- knowing that they only had Finn's best interests at heart. When it came to their past, whatever it was, everyone seemed to be gaining more secrets by the hour. Especially Adora. What made things even worse is how bad their mom was at hiding secrets. They huffed, crossing their arms as

they watched Adora step out of her office and close the door, somehow looking even more stressed than she had ten minutes ago.

"Okay Finn, I'll be back in an hour or so, give or take, I have a-parent teacher meeting at the school."

Finn knew she was lying through her teeth, "Okay."

"We have pizza leftover from yesterday. Call me if you need anything, alright?"

"I will, mom." The tense air in the room left them both staring at each other for moment. The silence was loud, especially for Finn.

Nodding, Adora took a deep breath, grabbing her keys off the entrance table before taking her leave. Finn waited a few minutes, listening for the sound of Swifty driving away before glancing towards the office. They shouldn't- they knew they should just wait until Adora said something herself, but at this rate it felt like they were never going to get the answers they needed. Huffing, they got to their feet, making their way into the hallway and then Adora's office. They bit their lip, ears pinning momentarily before determination took over, and they pushed the door open.

They were going to get answers, even if they had to get them on their own.

⚔

Catra tightened her hold on Scorpia's arm as the three stepped into the law firm. Her memories of the past few days were- fuzzy, time had been nothing but a blur. She still felt numb, her brain wracked with thoughts screaming at her that this was just a false promise, that it wasn't going to get anywhere, and she was going to be right back where she was two days ago.

"It's gonna be alright, Wildcat." Scorpia promised, offering her a smile and leading her through the front door as Entrapta opened it for them.

"We'll see…" She mumbled, ears pinning as the stares began. How popular had her case gotten? Maybe it was just that obvious, maybe that social worker had a big mouth, maybe it was because she was a magicat. She didn't care anymore. She was here for one reason and one reason alone.

The reality and the earth crushing gravity of the situation began to weigh heavier on her chest as she ascended the stairs with her friends, making their way to the first room on the left, as they had been instructed to. As they stepped into the room, they were met with two women, one with a laptop that she assumed was Mara, and a blonde woman that reminded her instantly of Finn. Was it the hair? She saw hundreds of blondes, so that wasn't it. Her eyes-

She stared, pupils dilating slightly. It was definitely the woman's eyes. They were almost the same shade of blue as Finn's.

"Catra?"

Flinching, the brunette looked at Entrapta, who smiled at her, before motioning to the chair in front of her, "Oh- uh- thank- thank you." She muttered, slowly taking a seat between her friends.

"Alright, Catra Dr'iluth, this is Adora Grayskull, the woman who adopted Finn." Mara started simply, "Why don't you start by telling us why exactly you wanted this meeting."

Catra could practically see the distrust radiating off of Mara, but for some reason, not this- Adora. She simply waited, patient and relaxed. She seemed more intrigued, maybe a little nervous, over anything else, "I- I just, uhm…" She took a deep breath, taking Entrapta's offered hand and squeezing it lightly, "I need to know- know that Finn is- okay. I need to know they've had a good home, a good life…"

Adora frowned; Catra wasn't sure if the look on her face was sympathy or pity- maybe both, "I like to think I've been a good parent. I love Finn, so much. They're my world and I've done my best to give them everything they've ever wanted or needed. They have their own room, lots of friends and family members.."

“Do they know about me?” The question slipped out sooner than she had wanted it to- but she was just so desperate to know.

“I…” Adora bit her lip. She felt a wave of guilt crush her heart. The way Catra’s ears pinned told her everything, “I’ve always planned to. You understand as well as I do that this is- a really unique situation, and I wanted to wait until they were old enough to understand.”

“So they haven’t gotten my letters. What- did you burn them? Throw them out?” Catra furrowed her eyebrows, glaring.

“No! No- I would never. They’re all safe. I’ve kept them all, and I promise I have always planned to give them to Finn. I know they’re old enough now, I should- I should have already said something before this meeting I just- I just needed to meet you first. You understand it’s hard when I don’t know your intentions, right..?”

“My *intentions?* What does that even mean?”

“I…” Adora looked at the table. She felt awful.

“I know I don’t deserve to ever see them again. I know they probably won’t want to once they find out who I am, but I need to- I just need them to know how much I love them. I-” Tears were running down her face before she could stop them.

“I don’t think that. You… you need to see them.” Adora spoke as the realization dawned. She swallowed the lump in her throat, “You care, you just want to see your baby again. I- Fuck, I’m so sorry…” She shook her head, wiping her eyes to stop tears of her own, “I’m such an idiot.”

Catra stared in disbelief at what she was hearing. Was she hearing this right? There was no way she was hearing this right, “..W-What?”

Adora took a deep breath, “You need to see Finn. You deserve to- I- I’m sorry I made you wait even this long…”

“Adora you don’t have to-”

Adora held up a hand, stopping Mara from finishing whatever she was about to say, “I’ve made my decision.” She said simply, before pulling out a piece of paper and pen from her satchel, jotting down her name and number before sliding it over to Catra, “I would like to ask that I have at least tomorrow to explain some things to them, but after that, feel free to call or message me anytime about setting up a meeting day, and we can go from there. Okay?”

Catra was speechless. Was this… real? She blinked a few times, gently taking the paper and sliding it into her pocket, “T-Thank you I… *thank you* .”

Adora nodded, smiling warmly at the brunette, "..Oh! One more thing- I thought that maybe you'd like to have this." She pulled a small framed photo out of her satchel and handed it over, "They had picture day last month, I had an extra copy."

Catra's breath hitched and her ears pinned as she took the photo, turning it over slowly. Tears ran down her face as she stared at the picture. It was hard knowing that the last time she had seen them they had just started to pick out words and phrases in books, and now they were in high school, but seeing their bright smile brought her so much joy, "…thank you…" She whispered, "so much.."

Adora nodded, smiling, "I need to get back home, but please, call me anytime." She said as she stood, pulling her satchel over her shoulder.

"I will.." Catra continued to stare at the photo. She couldn't believe things had gone *this* well.

⚔

..I'm so sorry that things turned out this way, little one. I don't want you to think I left you- I did everything I could to keep you with me. You mean the world to me, and I hope you never forget how much I love you..

..There are no words to explain how badly I wish I had stopped that trigger, that I didn't allow the world to separate us; you were so young, too young to understand..

..I hope and pray that the family that took you in give you every bit of the love and care and time that I wish I could give you. I know they will probably never give these to you, and I can't blame them for that, all things considered. I can't blame them, and I hope you don't either..

..I love you, I love you so much, little one. Nothing I've done in my life will ever change that. You mean everything to me, and I hope that by some miracle that I get to see you again one day..

..If I ever get the chance to see you again, I promise I will find a way to make all of these years up to you, Finn..

..Never forget how proud of you I am, little one. I love you.

~ Catra Dr'iluth (Momma)

Finn had tears streaming down their face as they stared at the letter in their hand, body trembling as everything they had just read slowly sunk in. Their mom had been arrested? They had been in prison for the past- ten years or so? The crime was never said directly, only mentioning a trigger being pulled once or twice. Murder?

“Finn! I need to talk to you about-” Adora froze as she passed her office, seeing the box, simply labeled ‘Dr’iluth’, the hundreds of letters scattered around Finn, who was staring at her, ears pinned, tear-stained face, and trembling body, “Finn… I..”

“When?” They glared, *hissing* when Adora tried to step closer. The action made Adora’s breath hitch. Finn had been angry, upset, yelled at her before. Of course they had. But they had *never* hissed at her.

“Finn-”

“WHEN? When were you going to t-tell me about her?!”

“Today, Finn. I was just about to-”

“Sure you were!” They glared, “You really expect me to believe that?!” They scooped up the pile of letters and shoved them back into the box, grabbing it as they stood up. They shoved past Adora before making their way into their bedroom. Adora wasn’t surprised to hear the door lock after it slammed closed. She sighed, sitting down in her chair.

She sniffed, wiping her eyes as tears ran down her face. What was she gonna do now?

Reunion

Chapter Summary

The title. >:3

Adam couldn't say he was surprised to hear a knock at the door. Sure, it was usually abnormal to have visitors at eleven at night, but his sister had already messaged him about his nibling's-discoveries. It made sense they would want time away from home for a few hours. He gave Teela a knowing nod before getting off the couch and making his way to the door. As soon as he opened it, Finn all but threw themselves into their uncle's arms.

He wrapped his arms around Finn, gently closing the door and guiding them over to the couch to sit between him and their aunt, "I'm sorry you had to find out this way, kiddo.."

"Did everyone k-know..?!" Finn sniffed, trying to glare at them but unable to muster the energy to do so.

"We did, but it was Adora's job to tell you about it," Teela softly explained, running a hand through their hair, "And she was going to tell you today. You just- ran out of patience a little too early."

"Can you blame me!?"

Teela sighed, shaking her head, "No, and I don't. None of us do, including Adora. You have to understand, this is a really complex

thing that isn't easy to explain to kids, or teenagers."

Finn sighed, ears folding back, "I guess…"

"Do you wanna know where Adora was today?" Adam asked, to which the teenager quickly nodded, "She was meeting with- Her today."

Finn's gaze shot up to meet their uncle, "What?!"

Adam held up a finger, "And is going to let you meet her too. I don't know when that will be, but please understand, Finn, Adora has always and always will only want what is best for you. She needed to know it was safe for you, and she needed to protect you."

New tears ran down Finn's cheeks. They wrapped their tail around their legs as they pulled them to her chest, "Do… do you know what my- what she did? I read the letters, and I think I know but…"

"She killed someone, Finn." Teela quietly replied, starting to rub their back as she spoke, "I believe a fight had broken out and ended with her… you know. Adora told us what happened at the meeting before she told us about you finding the letters. She said that Catra really loves you and misses you, and wants the best for you too."

Finn sat there for a few minutes, a quiet purr starting to keep themselves calm. Adam and Teela stayed there, providing comfort so they could think, waiting to see where Finn wanted to go from there. After five minutes of semi-silence, only Finn's purrs and the mutters from the TV filling the room, the blonde finally spoke again, "You can tell mom where I am, if you haven't already. I wanna stay here tonight, and I'll talk to her tomorrow. I wanna meet her- I wanna meet Catra, soon. I want to decide for myself if I want her in my life. Mom doesn't get to make that choice anymore."

Adam nodded, "Alright kiddo. Adora won't have a problem with that, I promise. You can go crash in your room if you're tired, raid the pantry, you know our house is just as much yours."

Finn smiled slightly, giving them both a hug before standing up, "Thank you, I think I'm gonna grab some water and lay down."

"Okay, honey. Let us know if you need anything." Teela smiled, ruffling their hair before they hurried to the fridge, grabbing a bottle of water before scampering down the hall to their room. It was technically a guest bedroom, but Finn had decorated it, and was the only one who had ever used it aside from Adora.

Sighing, Adam pulled out his phone, FaceTiming Adora, who answered almost immediately.

"Adam? Is Finn with you?"

“Yes, sis, they’re with me, and they’re fine. They wanna stay here tonight, and will talk to you tomorrow.”

“They also want to meet Catra soon.” Teela added.

“I’ll reach out to her after I talk to Finn if she hasn’t messaged me by then.” Adora sighed, running her fingers through her hair, “Thank you for taking care of them.”

“You know we are always happy to watch our nibling, Adora,” Teela smiled, “Besides, better they come here than run off on their own or something.”

“That’s true…” Adora felt panic in her chest at the mere thought of not knowing where her child was, “I guess I’ll be over in the morning. Around ten or eleven?”

“Sounds good. We’ll all be ready.” Adam promised, “Love you, sis.”

“Love you too. Love you Teela, I’ll see you guys tomorrow.”

“See you tomorrow.” The couple waved before letting the call drop.

“Well, should we call it a night too?” Teela asked, the blonde shrugging.

“Yeah, sounds like it’s gonna be a big day tomorrow.” Adam chuckled, taking his partner’s hand before turning off the TV. Teela flicked the light off as they walked out into the hallway and down to their own room for the night.

⚔

Adora was nervous. She knew Finn had a slightly better understanding of everything now. Adam had told her they explained the outline of things, but left any missing details and in between to her. She thought she would have more time to prepare, but really, when would she have actually been prepared for this?

Adam worked early mornings, and Teela had left not long after Adora arrived, leaving her some privacy to talk to Finn. She bit her lip as the teen walked into the kitchen, plopping down on the chair across from her at the table, “Ask me anything. If I know the answer, I promise to tell you.”

Finn nodded, fidgeting with their tail as they stared at the floor, “When did you first find out who my mom was?”

“When I was finalizing the adoption. They told me that you had been in the system for around three months, and you were

extremely closed off. You probably don't remember, but the first time I met you, you clawed my hand when I held it out to you and curled up in the corner of the room. I knew you were just scared, as you had every right to be. You did good though! You left a scar," Adora chuckled, showing her palm to Finn, where a tiny scar reached from the middle of her palm to the bottom of her pointer finger, "You looked so surprised when I didn't get angry and leave, and after two more visits you started warming up to me, and I was able to bring you home soon after.." Adora smiled, fondly remembering the day she'd brought little Finn home, curled up in her arms and scent marking her shoulder. Everyone had been surprised at how fast Finn accepted Adora, but it was a welcome one, "Anyway.. Mara told me that your mother had been arrested and what for. She told me that once she was released, she could ask to see Finn, but it was ultimately up to me."

Finn furrowed their eyebrows at that, "Well- I wanna choose now."

"And you can, you will. You're old enough to make that choice, and I'm sorry for not telling you sooner."

"I forgive you." Finn hummed, slowly getting up and walking into Adora's waiting arms, "I love you, mom.."

"I love you too, Finn." Adora smiled, kissing the top of their head.

"…What did you think when you met her?"

“I.. I think she loves you very much, and she wants nothing more than to see you again. I think that thinking of you is what got her through those ten years. All she seemed to care about was knowing that you were safe and had a good life.”

“Has she messaged you yet?”

“No, I asked her to give me today to explain everything to you. Would you like me to message her today?”

Finn quickly nodded, “Yes, please…”

“Okay. I’ll text her once we get home. Are you ready to head back?”

“Yeah… So I don’t have to go to school?”

Adora laughed, “It’s Friday, enjoy a three day weekend.”

“Yes!” Finn exclaimed, laughing when their mom ruffled their hair.

“Come on, goofball.” Adora stood, making sure all the lights were out before they left, locking up behind them.

⚔

Catra stared at her phone, eyes wide and tears running down her face. It was the greatest thing she could have ever been sent, but something she never imagined getting to see:

Finn would like to meet you! Whenever you're free, let me know a good place and time so I can make that happen!

Once she got herself together enough to respond, she gave the soonest date possible.

I'm free today honestly- if that's okay. I get if it's not. Uhm, do you know where the Plumeria Park is? We can meet there?

Sounds great! We could meet at one?

Yeah. Yeah, that would be great! Thank you, thank you so much.

Of course. See you soon!

Unable to believe that she was just a few hours away from meeting her child, she laughed, wiping her eyes as she put her phone down and got out of bed. Scorpia and Entrapta were very

persistent about her resting after what had happened before the meeting with Adora, but nothing would stop her now.

~

Finn was nervous. They knew that was normal for this very abnormal situation. They were kicking their feet lightly, fidgeting with Adora's fingers. They hoped they had made the right choice- that they wouldn't regret this. Their mom assured them that it was completely up to them, but that when she had met Catra, it was clear they loved them and wanted the best for them.

If the meeting didn't go well, they could just never see her again, even if that would make them feel guilty. They had high hopes though, even if they didn't remember…

A scent suddenly hit their nose. It was- familiar. It was a scent they hadn't known for so long, but the second it hit them, it was immediate what it was for them.

Home.

Slowly, they looked behind them, and another magicat was standing a few feet behind the bench, just staring at them. They got to their feet, gaining Adora's attention. The blonde watched, offering Catra a smile before looking back to Finn, who was just staring at Catra still.

Seeing Catra for the first time filled in the fuzzy memories that had filled their dreams for as long as they can remember. Tears welled up in their eyes as they took a few steps forward, not dropping eye contact with the brunette. Then before they realized, they had run forward and launched themselves into her arms, surrounding themselves in that scent of Home they didn't know they had missed so dearly.

The next word said drew a sob out of Catra as she sunk to the ground, holding Finn as close as possible in her trembling arms.

"M-Mama.."

Revelations

Chapter Summary

We all knew this was coming 👀

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Finn had yet to move from Catra's arms. Adora had invited Catra to visit, and as soon as they got there, Finn had dragged her over the to couch and promptly sat in her lap and curled up. Adora had been watching the teen with a warm smile, relieved the reunion had gone so smoothly. Catra started purring, gently rubbing Finn's back as they somehow made themselves smaller in her arms, a quiet purr starting to match their mother's.

"Mama..?"

"Yes..?"

"I.. I missed you…"

"I missed you too, little one…" Catra whispered. The nickname made Finn feel warm in their chest. Memories of Catra calling them that flooded their mind. They nuzzled up to the brunette, lightly scent marking her shoulder.

Adora smiled, getting to her feet, “Do either of you want anything to drink?”

“Oh- no thank you-”

“Sweet tea please!” Finn announced immediately, tail wagging, “You should have some too, mama! It’s really good!”

Adora glanced to Catra, who nodded sheepishly, before returning her attention to Finn, “Alright, little one.” She smiled.

“Are you staying with us?”

That was the last question Catra expected them to ask her, making her flinch, “Oh I- I wasn’t- that would be up to your mom and I wouldn’t want-”

“But you’re my mama too.”

“I…”

“Finn, honey?”

“Yes?” The smaller blonde perked up, looking over the couch into the kitchen.

“Can you run downstairs and grab our laundry? My alarm just went off.”

“Sure!” The one thing Finn disliked about their apartment building- the laundry was all the way two floors down. Thank the stars for the elevator! They hopped to their feet, nuzzled their cheek to Catra’s, hurried to give Adora a hug, before grabbing the pop up laundry bag by the door and hurrying off out the door.

Adora waited a couple of seconds before making her way back to the couch, setting the three cups of sweet tea down on the coffee table before taking a seat next to the brunette, “I don’t want to sound judgmental or anything, because I am absolutely not trying to be when I ask this- do you have a place of your own?”

“I… I’ve been staying with my two best friends. They live in an apartment building a few blocks away. I- I had my own apartment… before, but my landlord was a jackass that made sure I couldn’t afford it.”

“I’m- I’m so sorry…” Catra shrugged, looking away, ears pinning, “Well, I want you to know you’re welcome here anytime, okay? I have a spare room, if Finn doesn’t just drag you to theirs.” Adora chuckled, “I don’t want you to lose anymore time with them than you already have.”

“T-thank you, Adora.. You’ve been more than generous.”

Nodding, Adora gave her shoulder a gentle squeeze, “Of course. I couldn’t imagine what you’ve gone through.”

“Mm..” Catra glanced around, her gaze landing on a few pamphlets on the side table, “Hearing aids?”

“Oh- yes, um.. Finn has been slowly losing their hearing in their left ear. I think it has something to do with whatever caused the scar on their cheek. I know they’re gonna need the hearing aid, but they said they aren’t ready yet. I give them maybe six more months before they’ll have to get it.”

Guilt swept through Catra. She bit her lip, flashes of the past running through her mind. She’d always wondered if they’d had any lasting effects from that night.

“I don’t… I don’t wanna pressure you, you don’t have to answer if you don’t want to, but Finn had that scar on their cheek when I adopted them. Do you- do you know how they got that?”

Slowly, very slowly, Catra nodded. She barely moved her head, but Adora saw it, “Yes…” Her voice was barely a whisper.

“How…? If- you don’t mind me asking..”

“You- you wouldn’t b-believe me..”

“Catra…” Adora took a deep breath, slowly reaching over and taking her hand, “Despite everything that I’ve been told about you- I can tell that next to none of it was true. I can just- I know, I know, you’re a good mom. A good person. You have done nothing but be honest and vulnerable with me, which I know has to be so hard. Whatever you tell me, if you choose to, I promise I’ll believe you.”

Tears welled up in the brunette’s eyes. She searched Adora’s eyes for insincerity, but found none, “They…” She took a deep breath, taking a few moments to collect herself, “…they got it the day that-…” Tears ran down her face. She unconsciously leaned against the blonde, “…They got it when they shot our landlord…”

Adora froze, eyes widening, “I’m- sorry… what?”

“Finn… Finn was the one that pulled the trigger… not me. I was yelling at her, trying to tell her I needed another week to finish paying rent because, because I only had enough money to feed Finn, but she didn’t care…” She sniffed, wiping her eyes, “I kept a gun in my bedside table drawer for protection because the neighborhood was shit and well, people aren’t always the kindest to- my kind. They found it and, and while I’m yelling I suddenly hear a shot behind me… I turn around and- there they are, holding the gun. I hear the woman hit the floor, and…”

"…and you spent ten years in prison for a complete accident."

Catra gave a small, bitter laugh, "What was I supposed to do? It didn't matter what I said. A wealthy, human woman was dead and a magicat woman of color had a gun. I knew there was no point in trying to tell them what really happened. No one believed anything that wasn't my confession. Even if they had believed me, they would have found another way to press charges on me and used that to take Finn from me."

Adora frowned, tears ran down her face. She understood discrimination well herself. Not everyone was as accepting of her transition as her friends and family, but she knew whatever she had faced was nothing compared to what Catra had gone through, "I… I understand, being treated differently."

Catra glanced up at her, raising an eyebrow.

"I'm… I'm trans. I transitioned years ago, and mostly, it's fine now, but when I was just out of surgery, only a year on estrogen, it was- more obvious. I know it was nothing compared to you, but I just- didn't want you to feel so alone."

"Thanks… I- I appreciate it."

They flinched when the door opened, Finn slowly walking in, setting the laundry basket next to the entrance as they closed it, "It was me…?"

The women's eyes widened, "Oh- Finn I…" Catra watched as they approached, rounding to the front of the couch and sitting next to the brunette.

"I… I'm sorry…"

"Finn, baby no.." Catra enveloped the teen into a hug, "You didn't know what you were doing.. You were only three years old."

"I'm still sorry anyway… for what you went through."

"It's over now, little one…" Catra whispered, gently rubbing Finn's back, "It's all okay now…"

Finn purred quietly, nuzzling their face against her shoulder, "Can you stay tonight…?"

Catra glanced at Adora, who smiled and nodded, "Sure, baby…" She hummed, starting to purr herself. The two carefully curled up against the couch, letting the tension melt away as Catra held her kit close to her. Adora smiled, she slowly wrapped her arms around both of them, relieved when Catra purred louder and relaxed against her. Sighing, Adora rested her head against the couch, closing her eyes.

She needed to talk to Glimmer.

Soon.

Chapter End Notes

A little bit of a shorter chapter, but I feel like so much happened! djksfhdsf

Listen

Chapter Summary

Catra finally gets a chance to tell her story.

Her real story.

The sun rays slowly spilled into the room through the blinds and curtains, hitting Catra in the face and slowly waking her. She slowly opened her eyes, blinking and yawning. She tensed when she felt someone move, and looked down to see Finn curled up against her, fast asleep. She smiled, starting to purr as she wrapped her arms around them. They must have slipped into the room sometime throughout the night after she fell asleep. Taking a deep breath, looking around the guest room. It was simple, painted a sage green with the basic furniture, but it was nice-cozy even. She smiled, her purr getting stronger when she heard Finn trill and snuggle in closer. Gently, Catra ran her fingers through their blonde hair, eliciting another trill from the teen.

She flinched when there was a gentle knock at the door, "Come in.." She called as quietly as possible. She smiled when Adora opened the door and stepped into the room.

"So that's where they went. I guess I shouldn't be surprised." Adora chuckled, "Did you sleep well?"

"Better than I have in years…" Catra smiled, "Thank you so much…your hospitality has been more than I could ever asked for…"

“Of course.” The blonde smiled, taking a seat in the chair next to the dresser, “I think we should talk to my friend, Glimmer.”

Catra raised an eyebrow, “Why?”

“She’s a lawyer, and a very good friend of mine. She works with the Brightmoon Law Department; she could have you exonerated.”

“That’s…” Catra sighed, her ears folding back, “That’s a nice thought, Adora, but… I have everything that I need now. It doesn’t matter anymore, and it won’t change anything.”

“It could, though! It would do so much to help the fight against discrimination, and the corrupt people in the justice system.”

“Adora… I have everything I ever wanted back in my arms, I’m tired. I don’t need to go through the system again…”

“I think it would be good for you..”

The women looked down to see Finn yawning and moving to grip onto Catra’s shirt, “Finn..”

“I know it’s scary, mama… the system wasn’t nice to me either before Mara or mom, but good things can come after the hard parts…” Finn smiled up at her.

“I don’t know…”

“We could at least go talk to her? If you still don’t want to then… then we can leave it alone, but I feel like you deserve justice for what was done to you.”

Sighing, Catra relented, nodding, “Okay, fine..” Slowly, she sat up, holding Finn as they continued to cling to her, “But don’t expect anything to come out of it. Trust me.”

“You never know!” Finn smiled, wrapping their arms around her shoulders, “There’s no harm in trying!”

“You’re right, little one, there isn’t..” Catra hummed, touching her forehead to theirs, “I love you, Finn…”

“I love you too, mama…” Finn smiled, purring quietly.

Adora sniffed and wiped her eyes, drawing the attention of the magicat’s, “Sorry- Sorry. This is just so sweet. I’ll give you a moment, and go start breakfast. Any requests?” She asked as she got to her face.

“Waffles!” Finn exclaimed, making Catra giggle. She gave Adora a thumbs up, who smiled before leaving the room to head to the kitchen.

⚔

"Adora, you know how I feel about her and you bring her to my office!? What were you thinking?!”

“Glimmer, she didn’t do it!” Adora glared.

“She could be lying!”

“It makes sense, Glimmer! Finn’s scar, their impending deafness, the memory issues. It all makes total sense! And you know discrimination is a big issue in the justice system! Please, give her a chance? If not for her, for Finn?”

Glimmer stared into her best friend’s eyes, glaring as long as she could before sighing, “Fine. I’ll give her half an hour.”

Adora smiled, wrapping her arms around her, “Thank you! Thank you!”

“Gah! Adora- crushing me!”

Blushing, the blonde gently let her go and took a step back, “Sorry, sorry-!”

Glimmer chuckled, “It’s fine, just- go bring them in here before I change my mind.”

Smiling, Adora stepped out of the office and waved to Catra and Finn, who were sitting on a couch in the waiting area. The two slowly got up and made their way over to Adora, following her into the office. Glimmer did her best not to grimace when the two walked in, taking a seat next to Adora on the couch next to her desk, “Hey Auntie Glimmer!”

“Hey, Finn.” Glimmer smiled momentarily, before turning her attention to Catra, “So, I need you to walk me through exactly what happened that day, as well as what happened after you were arrested. If you want me to make a case, I’m gonna need all the help I can get.”

Ears pinned back, Catra slowly nodded, “Right- uhm, okay…” She took a deep breath, suddenly nervous. She’d never had a chance to tell her story. Her real story. It had always been twisted the lies the system wanted to be true, “Should I start at that day or…?”

“Just- a bit of what led up to it and then go from there.” Glimmer sighed, waving her hand airily.

"Okay…" Catra closed her eyes, flinching when she felt a hand take her own. She glanced down, smiling when she realized it was Finn, smiling up at her, silently assuring and urging her to go on, "My landlord- Her name was Sharon Weaver. Not to speak ill of the departed, but she was a bitch, and that's putting it lightly. I only moved into her apartment building because I literally couldn't afford anything else. It was small, just a single bedroom, a bathroom, and an open room with a couch and compact kitchen. She told me it would be five hundred a month, which I could just barely make along with taking care of a newborn kit and myself. It worked for a few years, I worked three different jobs. During the day I worked at a small diner as a waitress, and every other night I worked at a gas station. Then on weekends I was a bartender. I didn't have enough to afford a babysitter, obviously, so I asked my best friends too. Entrapta and Scorpia, they watched Finn for me when I wasn't home. I spent as much time as I could with them though- and it was everything I could have ever asked for to come home to Finn jumping into my arms, showing me their newest drawing or telling me about the story they made up with their tías…" Catra let her eyes drift closed again as she spoke, memories of her life before prison flooding her mind, "I could only ever provide them with the bare minimum, but I always tried to spoil them on their birthdays, during solstice, special holidays. Anyways, not long after Finn's fifth birthday, Sharon showed up, telling me that my rent was going up to six hundred and fifty from now on, knowing- *knowing* that I wouldn't be able to afford it! We started arguing- I told her I would be out of there at the end of the lease, but I would need extra time if she wanted me to pay an additional hundred and fifty every month." Catra scoffed at the memory, "She told me would throw me to the streets before giving me extra time, that I had better have my payment ready by the end of the week. I started yelling at her, telling her she knew I couldn't afford it, that she was doing it on purpose because she was a racist bigot with nothing better to do. She insisted she didn't know what I was talking about- that it was just 'business' and I was just trying to use the 'race card'." She took a moment to

breathe, her eyebrows furrowing before she continued, "The neighborhood we lived in wasn't safe- especially for small kids and magicats, so I kept a gun in my side table. I hid it the best I could- I honestly didn't know that Finn even knew I *had* the thing. I guess they wandered into our room and found it. It was my fault it wasn't on safety, but the next thing I knew, there was a shot fired behind me and Sharon had hit the floor. When I turned around, Finn was on the floor, crying and holding their face. Everything else just- went out the window. I was on my knees next to them, cradling them close and promising that everything was going to be okay…" She sniffed, wiping her eyes, "I don't know who called 911, but they showed up before I could get to my phone while holding Finn. Sharon was already dead, I think, I didn't care- I just wanted Finn to get some help, and I begged them for it- for them to take us to the hospital, but…"

"They- assumed you did it, didn't they..?" Glimmer asked, her eyes glossy. Adora and Finn were shedding silent tears of their own.

Catra nodded slowly, tensing at the memory, "They saw the gun and me and her and just… grabbed me- took Finn from me and slammed me to the ground and cuffed me on the spot. I never got to say goodbye to Finn or- or tell them how much I loved them I…" Her breath hitched when Finn's arms wrapped tightly around her torso. She looked down at them, tears running down her face as she returned the embrace.

"I love you mama… and I know now how much you loved me then too… it's okay…"

“I love you too, little one…” Catra whispered, kissing the top of their head.

“What happened after you were arrested?”

“Huh?” Catra looked back to Glimmer, “Oh- right, yeah. They took me to the Brightmoon Police Station. I was told I was being charged with first degree murder, booked into the jail, then taken to an interrogation room. The officers handed me a piece of paper and told me to write a confession. Then they left me alone for two hours.”

“Two hours?!” Glimmer gaped, “Alone? No bathroom breaks, water, nothing?!”

Catra shook her head, “When they came back, I hadn’t finished, because I was too worried about Finn. I asked about them, but they just told me that they were no longer my concern, and that I would regret it if I didn’t finish the confession within the next half hour. So… I did. When they came back the second time, they cuffed me and took me to a cell.”

“What happened during the trial?”

“They ripped me apart. They spilled my entire life story about my father’s deaths, my struggle to maintain living only to get myself pregnant after a drunk night at the bar. They forced me to admit my hatred towards Weaver, then used it to give a motive. They

painted me as a psychotic woman that wasn't fit to live among society, much less be a mother."

"I.. I'm so sorry, Catra…" Glimmer gasped, eyes wide as she tried to process everything she'd just heard, "I never liked Horde Prime, I knew he would go far to win his cases but… this is just unjust! Illegal even! I…" She wiped her eyes, "I'm so sorry, of course I'll take the case, and I'm going to make sure that you're not only exonerated, but also help you sue Prime and the police department. I know there's no amount of money that can make up those ten years you lost, but I hope it will help you live the rest of them comfortably."

Catra smiled, "Thank you… you're the first person aside from Adora and Finn who have believed me, though you're the first in the justice system to listen and believe me."

Finn purred, hugging Catra again after hopping into her lap, "See, mama! It's all gonna be okay!"

"Yeah… yeah you did, little one. You sure did…" Catra sniffed, wiping her eyes before resting her forehead to her child's.

"And this time, you're going to have a much bigger support system to make sure it's done right." Adora promised, placing a hand on the brunette's shoulder.

Catra was feeling so many emotions, she wasn't sure how she was supposed to handle them all at once. Tears continued to run down her face, but she couldn't get a smile off of her face now! She laughed, hugging Finn tighter, and slowly leaning on Adora when the blonde wrapped her arm around her.

"I'll start writing up the case tonight, and I'll be in contact with you as soon as I get any news." Glimmer assured, grabbing her business card off her desk and handing it to Catra, who gently took it and slid it into her pocket.

"Thank you… so, *so* much."

"Of course. I won't lie to you, the case is going to be huge, and it's going to take time and be stressful, but I have a few friends that will be happy to help me reopen the case and find *real* evidence that the jury can't ignore."

Catra nodded, relaxing for the first time in over a decade. She couldn't believe that this meeting had not only turned out well, but with more than she could have ever hoped for!

⚔

"This is so amazing, Wildcat!" Scorpia gasped, pulling the brunette into her arms, "I'm so proud of you!"

“You should be thanking those two- I wouldn’t have gone otherwise…”

“You are looking so much better than when we last saw you. I can’t believe you’re the first ever recorded case of cured Grieving!” Entrapta exclaimed, “I have so much research to do! Of course, I will prioritize this new trial first.”

“Wait- Grieving?” Adora asked, raising an eyebrow.

“Oh it’s a fascinating but terrible disease! It’s when-”

“Let’s- not go into that right now, ‘Trapta… ‘kay?”

Nodding, the scientist gave a sheepish grin, “Sorry. Makes sense!”

“Anyway, I say this calls for a celebration dinner!” Scorpia clapped.

“Yeah! Plus, it would give me time to catch up with you two and you guys can get to know mom!” Finn smiled, laughing when Scorpia scooped them up in her arms.

“I can’t believe how big you are now, Squirt! I know you’re fifteen now, but the last time I held you you were calling me Tía Scorps and Entrapta Tía Traps.”

Finn blushed, but giggled, “Awe, jeez. I thought I had a lot of aunties before.”

“Well you got two more now!” Entrapta smiled, patting their head gently, “Now, where are we off to for a celebration meal?”

“We could go to the Seaworthy Buffet.” Adora suggested, “It’s Finn’s favorite.”

“Sounds good to me.” Catra smiled.

“Absolutely!” Scorpia agreed, looking to Entrapta, who gave a smile and a thumbs up.

“Seaworthy it is then.” Adora smiled, laughing when Finn pumped their fists in the air with a cheer.

“Yes!!”

Hearing

Chapter Summary

> "Is everyone ready for this hearing to begin its proceedings?" Judge Norwyn asked, nodding once everyone took their seats at their respective tables, "Good. Now, would you please state the reason you have called this hearing, Mrs. Arrow-Moon?"
>
> "Yes, thank you Your Honor." Glimmer smiled, adjusting the files on the table before getting to her feet, "Catra has recently come to me and explained the horrific mockery that has been made of our justice system, and the very laws that we work so hard to uphold. The story that was forced out of her on the stand was mostly lies, conspiracies made up the Brightmoon Police Department and Prime himself. I am here to request a retrial, an appeal, a chance for the truth to come out, for what really happened that day to be brought to light, so that the injustices may be able to be compensated for."

Chapter Notes

> Another update for you! We're moving forward with the appeal to free our favorite brunette of these wrongful convictions!
>
> CW// Magicat Slur, Misgendering, Racism/Specism (Horde Prime)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"This was a terrible idea, Sparkles…" Catra tried to sound snappy, angry, but her voice came out sounding like a whispered mewl. She tensed for a moment when she felt Finn grasp her hand. She gave them a small smile of gratitude.

"It's gonna be okay, mama, I promise." Finn assured, "Auntie Glimmer is a great lawyer, Prime doesn't stand a chance."

Catra offered her kit a smile, but Adora and Glimmer could tell she was scared, terrified even. She let out a shaky breath as they entered the room, doing her best to ignore the smirk that Prime was already sending her way.

Why am I doing this?

This is never going to work.

They're just going to throw you back in jail.

Leave.

Get out of here. Now! Before-

"Is everyone ready for this hearing to begin its proceedings?" Judge Norwyn asked, nodding once everyone took their seats at their respective tables, "Good. Now, would you please state the reason you have called this hearing, Mrs. Arrow-Moon?"

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"You are suggesting that we retry a convicted murderer for a crime that was tried and closed ten years ago? I fail to see the reason why this needs to happen." Prime intruded, getting to his feet also, smiling calmly, "Would it not be better to let this-magicat move forward from this?"

Catra furrowed her eyebrows, but said nothing. She couldn't meet his eyes even if she tried. Instead, she kept her eyes on the table, though she could feel Finn and Adora's eyes on the back of her head, worried for her and angry at Prime.

Norwyn considered everything he'd heard. He sighed, "What evidence do you have of these injustices?" He asked, clasping his hands together in front of him.

"Catra has told me her story in great detail, and her child, Finn, has started to regain their memories of that night, and is old enough now to speak on it."

"So… you only have spoken word?"

"Well, I have other evidence, but I'd rather not bring that up outside of an actual trial. Your Honor, all I am asking is to give Catra the chance she deserves to let the truth out, to exonerate her for a crime I believe she did not commit."

Norwyn looked taken aback by this, "That is an entirely different thing from just telling her story, Mrs. Arrow-Moon."

"Not necessarily. Well, the story, her story- the truth, is what will prove she is innocent. Please, what I have heard is pure corruption in our court and department, and it is our duty to make sure the proper justice is carried out."

Prime stepped up next to Glimmer, towering over her, "You are suggesting we retry her for a crime she has already been convicted and prosecuted for. Does this mean that if she is retried and found guilty once again, she should face a second punishment?"

Catra's eyes widened as she looked up. That couldn't happen? Could it?

Norwyn narrowed his eyes, "No, Prime. We do not punish one for the same crime twice. You should know that after so many years in office, no?" He ignored the way Prime glowered at him and kept talking, "This, 'retrial', should I grant it, will be considered an appeal of her conviction that, if found innocent, will have her

record wiped clean of the charges of and related to the murder. If not, the charges will remain, and that will be the end of it."

"Please, consider the motion, Your Honor." Glimmer was almost pleading now, "We have an entirely new witness now and-"

"What you *have* is a scarred little boy with blurred memories that can be considered no more than speculation and conspiracy."

"Excuse me!?" Adora snapped, standing about the same time Catra and Glimmer did the same to yell,

"Finn isn't a boy!"

Finn crossed their arms, glaring at Prime.

"Everyone, calm down." Norwyn tapped his gavel once, before turning his attention to Finn, "This can be cleared up easily. How would you like to be addressed, Finn?"

Suddenly feeling bashful, their tail wrapped around Adora's leg, "I'm non-binary, they/them, please."

The judge nodded, "Thank you, Finn." He looked to Prime, who rolled his eyes.

"Whatever. My point still stands. *They* have only memories that are blurred and can't be taken as fact without some form of evidence that can be proven as fact."

"I have that, don't worry." Finn smirked, leaning against Adora when she sat back down to wrap her arms around them.

Norwyn stayed silent for a few minutes, before taking a deep breath, "In light of everything, I believe that there is reason to grant a retrial for the appeal. I will set it for next Monday and give you a week to prepare all of the evidence that you need to prove Catra's innocence." He tapped his gavel again to dismiss everyone, who stood and made their way out of the courtroom.

"You really think you'll be able to prove a crime that happened ten years ago didn't happen at her hands?" Prime asked, arms behind him as he approached Glimmer.

"I do, actually yes." Glimmer smirked, "What's the matter? Afraid that I'm going to prove you wrong? Ooh, how sad that would be for your ego!"

Momentarily dropping his composure, Prime turned and glared down at her, "What I don't understand is why you care about the degenerate enough to listen to whatever ridiculous story she's told you. That little Stray isn't worth your time, much less the court's!"

Catra's eyes shrunk to pinpricks, but she held herself together enough to hold Adora back, who looked ready to jump him.

Glimmer took a deep breath, "I'm going to pretend that wasn't just said in front of my fifteen year old nibling, and I'm going to suggest you leave now unless you want me to take this to my parents."

Glaring a moment longer, Prime adjusted his suit before turning away from them, "Very well. I wish you luck on this fruitless endeavor."

Glimmer chose not to respond, turning to the others, "I'm so sorry you had to hear that. Come on, let's get to my office and start preparing. I have a lot of things I need to subpoena and we have lots of statements to write."

Prime heard their footsteps fading, turning around to see Adora wrap an arm around Catra, who leaded into it, resting her head on her shoulder. Her tail moved to wrap around her waist.

"Interesting…"

⚔

"Why did you all react that way…?"

“What do you mean, honey?” Adora asked, looking to Finn when they suddenly put their phone down to face their mothers.

“The- word that Prime used that made mom wanna jump him?”

Oh.

Adora sighed, looking at Catra, “I only know a little bit about that sort of thing, maybe you could explain it better?”

Nodding, Catra patted the spot between her and Adora on the couch, which Finn was quick to take after abandoning their phone on the chair they were in before, “In short, it was a slur, little one. Kinda like how some people have slurs against queer people.”

“Oh… Makes sense, I guess. He was a dickhead.”

“Finn!” Adora tried to sound disapproving, but she was clearly trying not to laugh, “Language, please.”

“Come on, he was! I get a pass for being mis-gendered.”

Catra chuckled and ruffled their hair, "People like him try to treat magicats like animals. Kinda like…"

"Like that lady did..?"

Catra's ears perked up, looking at Finn in surprise, "What do you mean…?"

"The landlord… I remember she used to call you something, a slur I think. It wasn't the one Prime used though. She would always use it at least once when she visited."

"I'm.. I'm sorry you remember that, but yes, she did. I won't repeat that one either, but she loved to use it when she demanded rent she knew I didn't have."

Adora sighed, hugging them both gently, "I'm sorry you both had to deal with her. This whole mess is that woman's fault. If she hadn't been such a greedy bitch none of this would have happened."

"But then I wouldn't have you in my life…" Finn frowned, "I like you both as my moms…"

"Awe…"

“Finn…”

Both women smiled, hugging the kit, “Whaatt? You might as well be! I look like a perfect mix of you both anyway!”

“You…” Adora glanced between herself and Catra, “Huh. Yeah I-guess you’re right.”

Blushing, Catra cleared her throat, but before she could say anything, there was a knock at the door.

“Come in!” Adora called, smiling when Adam and Teela stepped into the room, “Hey Adam! Hey Teela!”

“Hey Uncle Adam and Auntie Teela!” Finn called, their tail wagging in excitement.

“Hey! We heard you have an appeal next week! Congratulations!” Teela smiled, “We also thought it was time we met Catra properly.”

Catra barely registered anything that was being said, her eyes focused on Adam. He looked just like the guy she’d met at the bar that night. Was it possible? It couldn’t be! The thought of how badly that would destroy the family’s dynamic was enough to make her panic.

“Mama…? Mama!”

Breath hitching, Catra blinked, a few tears running down her face. She quickly wiped them away and did her best to ignore the concerned looks everyone was giving her, “Sorry! I just, lost in thought I guess!” She laughed nervously, “It’s uh, it’s lovely to meet you both. A-Adam and Teela? Was it?” She cleared her throat, shaking Teela’s hand when she reached hers out to her.

“Mhm! Sorry about the intrusion, but Finn hasn’t stopped talking about you so we thought it was time we met. We haven’t gotten the full story yet, nor are we asking for it, but we understand that you didn’t actually commit that crime and are fully behind supporting you in getting exonerated.”

Slowly nodding, Catra smiled slightly, “Thank you. That- means a lot to me.”

“Oh! Adam, wanna help me set the table for dinner? We have tuna casserole in the oven and I just bought a new bottle of red wine to share.”

“Sure! I hope you didn’t make it though.” He teased, following after his sister.

“I didn’t! Catra did actually!” Adora laughed, lightly shoving her brother as they gathered what they needed to set the table.

“Are they twins?” Catra blurted, looking at Teela, who laughed.

“Yup! Identical at birth, but now, well. They still look super similar, but yes!”

Catra nodded, swallowing the lump in their throat. She knew Adora was transgender, which meant there was a fifty-fifty chance that Finn’s uncle was actually their father. She ran her fingers through her hair, trying to shake the thought out of her mind for now. She knew she would have to talk to Adora sometime about it, but she would do that when they were alone, and after the trial mess was taken care of. There was enough going on right now as it was.

“Are you sure everything’s okay, mama?” Finn asked, smiling when the brunette hugged them close.

“Yes, little one. I’m fine, I promise. Just, this entire thing is a lot for me. I don’t exactly trust the legal system.”

“Which is totally fair.” Teela chimed, “My father doesn’t either, and he was in the army for fifteen years.”

“Yeah… it just sucks that my entire life is gonna be spilled out to the court for a second time.” She sighed, “But, at least I actually have people to watch my back this time.”

“You didn’t before?” Teela frowned, sitting next to her.

“Kinda. I have two best friends, Scorpia and Entrapta. They did the best they could, but after I was arrested all they could do was sit in the courtroom and watch. They were questioned on the stand, and they stuck up for me, but none of it was concrete enough to keep me out of jail.”

“So… if you didn’t do it then who..?”

“I did..” Finn bit their lip, wincing when Teela gasped and looked at them.

“Wh- huh?!”

“They were only five, they didn’t know what they were doing. That’s why they have that scar and why their hearing is fading in that ear. Because of the kickback from the gun.”

“Wow I… I’m so sorry you had to deal with so much over an accident I..”

"It's fine. It led to all this so- I guess I can't complain all that much." Catra smiled sadly, relaxing when Finn leaned against her, hugging her from the side.

"Well, in any case, I'm still sorry. Nobody deserves to be treated the way you were."

"Thank you…"

⚔

"…yes, I know, Scorpia!… I will, okay! I love you too." Catra giggled before hanging up her phone and setting it on the nightstand.

"That's your best friend right?"

Flinching, Catra turned to see Adora standing in the doorway, "Oh- yeah. She and Entrapta are like the sisters I never had, the family I needed growing up."

"That's sweet." Adora smiled, "I didn't mean to intrude, I just heard you laughing on my way to my room.

“They were both excited about the appeal and wanted to ask a few questions and make sure I was okay since I haven’t been there in a while. I- I can always leave and go back, by the way. I don’t want you think I’m taking advantage of the situation or anything-”

“You’re not, I promise.” Adora smiled, “I’m happy to have you here, and I know Finn needs you around as much as you need them.”

“And you like having someone who can actually cook?” Catra couldn’t help the jab, smirking as she crossed her arms lightly.

Blushing heavily, Adora cleared her throat, “That is a big help and you can consider that sort of assistance as ‘payment’ or whatever if you feel guilty. Which please, don’t ever think you have to pay me for anything. I am so happy to have you around.”

Now blushing herself, Catra nodded slowly, her tail swaying gently behind her, “Okay..”

“Anyway, I’m headed to my room to work on that statement thing Glimmer asked me to write. I’ll- see you in the morning?”

“Yeah, I need to do the same. Goodnight, Adora. And.. And thank you.”

“Of course. Goodnight, Catra.” Adora hummed, waving before gently closing the door before walking down the hall.

Now smiling to herself, Catra sat down on the bed, grabbing the clipboard with the legal pad and pencil on it, before resting her head against the headboard. She could do this. She finally, finally had a chance to tell the world was really happened, and she couldn’t afford to waste it.

Chapter End Notes

I hope you all enjoyed! I would love to hear what you think about the story so far and what you think will happen next! Comments and kudos mean everything to me! <3

Paternity

Chapter Summary

> “Catra, come on, it’s so obvious you like her.”
>
> “I do not!”
>
> Scorpia gave Catra a deadpan stare until she groaned and looked away.
>
> “Whatever. I doubt she feels that way about me-”
>
> “-Girl she could literally be the other parent.” Lonnie intervened as she walked out of the kitchen, making the two women jump.
>
> “So? That was a hookup. It didn’t mean anything!”

Chapter Notes

> A little filler chapter between the hearing and the retrial chapter. Shorter- BUT I did FINALLY update this thing. I'm aiming for it to be 10-12 chapters total so we're getting close to the end!

“Are you alright?”

“Huh? Yeah, yeah, I’m fine. Just- a lot on my mind.” Catra muttered, not looking up as she wiped the bar down.

“Well, with all due respect, Wildcat, you look like you haven’t slept in a week.” Scorpia frowned, grabbing dirty glasses off of the counter and putting them into her dish bucket to take to the kitchen.

"I- I've been sleeping just- I realized something the other day and now I have no idea to approach it because it could ruin everything."

"What do you mean?" Scorpia raised an eyebrow.

Catra glanced around, making sure they were alone, despite the fact the bar was closed, before taking a deep breath, "Adam… Adora's brother, he- I saw him for the first time the night when the hearing happened, and he looks exactly like the guy I hooked up with that got me pregnant all those years ago…"

Eyes widening, Scorpia had to set the bucket on the counter before she dropped it, "You- Wow, okay that's- um- *wow* ."

"Yeah! How do I tell Adora that there's a huge chance her twin brother is Finn's dad?!"

Scorpia paused, "Wait wait wait, twin?"

"Yeah? So?" Catra shrugged.

"Like… like *identical* twin?"

“Scorpia what does this have to do with anything?” Catra huffed, crossing her arms.

“Well… Isn’t Adora transgender..?”

“What does that have to do with-” Catra froze when she realized what Scorpia was implying, “Oh holy *fuck* …” She groaned, ears folding back against her head, “It could be either one of them… how am I supposed to bring this up? I know I need to but- but it’s gonna be so *awkward !”*

“Well, look at it this way, if Adora is the other parent, that makes things a whole heck of a lot easier!” Scorpia laughed with a wink.

“Wh- what is that supposed to mean!?” Catra tried to glare, but her face was burning red.

“Catra, come on, it’s so obvious you like her.”

“I do not!”

Scorpia gave Catra a deadpan stare until she groaned and looked away.

“Whatever. I doubt she feels that way about me-”

"-Girl she could *literally* be the other parent." Lonnie intervened as she walked out of the kitchen, making the two women jump.

"So? That was a hookup. It didn't mean anything!"

"I'm just saying, there's always a chance! Besides, you like her don'cha?"

The smirk on Lonnie's face was too much for Catra in that moment, and the brunette groaned, turning away from everyone to try and hide how red her cheeks were turning, "It's getting late, I should be getting back. I promised Finn I'd help them cook dinner tonight."

"Mhmmm, have fun!" Lonnie teases, laughing when Catra groaned against as she made her way to the exit of the bar.

⚔

"…And then you just tie it off like this!" Catra smiled, letting go of the strand of hair she had braided for Adora, showing Finn one of the traditional Halfmoon braids.

Finn nodded, watching the example carefully, their tail swaying gently beside them on the couch. They had just finished dinner,

and had one of Finn's favorite shows on the TV in the background while they talked, "Too bad my hair isn't long enough for it huh?" They chuckled.

"That's okay, it's a good skill to have." Catra smiled, ruffling their hair, "But it's getting late. You should shower and get ready for bed, yeah?"

Though they pouted, Finn nodded, giving both of their moms a hug and a kiss on the cheek before scampering off down the hallway to the bathroom.

Catra waited until she heard the water running before turning towards Adora, who was smiling softly at her, "Hey, Adora? Can I… talk to you about something?"

"Sure, is everything okay?"

"Yes. No? I… I don't really know yet. Uhm… I think… I think I figured out who Finn's… other parent is."

That made Adora tense up. The idea of bringing yet another new parent into Finn's life was almost too much to even fathom, "O-Oh..? And- who…?"

"Well, it's a fifty-fifty shot between you and Adam."

That made Adora's eyes widen, "Wait- *what? "*

"That's why I freaked out the other day when I first saw Adam because he looked just like the guy I hooked up with at this bar all those years ago, and Teela told me you two are twins and- were identical before you transitioned, not that you aren't really close in appearance now I just- you know, and I-"

"-Whoa whoa, slow down." Adora gently took Catra's hands, "You said you hooked up with one of us at a bar…?"

Catra nodded, "When… when did you start your transition?"

"Around sixteen years ago… so yeah, the timing matches. It wasn't long after I started college… Adam and Teela have been together since tenth grade so…"

"So…" Catra paused for a moment, silence hanging between them until she started laughing, "Stars, what are the odds? That you and I… and you adopted…"

Giggling, Adora shook her head, "I'm gonna go with pretty slim. I mean, we should probably do a paternity test to be sure, right?"

Catra nodded, "Probably. It would be nice to have confirmation, even if we pretty much know."

"We can go in for it tomorrow on our way to Glimmer's office if you want. It shouldn't take too long."

"Sounds good. I guess we can tell Finn once we have the results?"

Adora nodded, "For now… did you, maybe wanna watch a movie…?"

Catra could see the light blush in Adora's cheeks, but she nodded nonetheless, smiling. She grabbed the remote and passed it to the blonde. Once they picked something to watch, Adora set the remote on the table before wrapping her arm around Catra's shoulders. Slowly, the brunette felt herself leaning into the hold, cuddling up to her friend. She took a deep breath. Things would be okay. Even if the conviction appeal didn't work, at least she got some good out of it that not even Prime or the jury could take away.

Innocence

Chapter Summary

> "Ready?"
>
> "As I'll ever be…" Catra sighs, standing up as well.
>
> "Okay. Finn, you're gonna sit at the table with Catra okay? Adora is gonna be in the first pew behind the table."
>
> Finn nodded. They took Catra's hand, and the four walked out into the courtroom. Adora followed an officer to sit in the pews, while Catra and Finn took their seats with Glimmer at the defense table.
>
> Unable to help herself, Catra glanced over at Prime, who was smirking, sitting calmly in his seat. He looked like he had already proven her guilty for a second time, like she had zero chance at being exonerated. She shakily exhales, looking at the table until Judge Norwyn began speaking.

Chapter Notes

> Ahhhhh! I know a lot of you have been waiting for Catra to get the justice she deserved, and it is finally here! I'm so excited to share this with you all and hear your thoughts!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra's leg bounced relentlessly as she sat in the side office to the courtroom, staring out the window. The last time she had been in this position, she had been in a jumpsuit, surrounded by cops and cuffed at the wrists and ankles. She had been drilled that she wasn't so say anything that didn't go along with her confession, that it was too late to change her story. She was younger then, and had no clue how things were supposed to work, so she had listened. That mistake, their corruption and racism, had cost her ten precious years of her life.

“Catra?”

She looked up as Adora walked into the room, Finn holding her hand, “Hey, Adora. Hey, little one.” She smiled, wrapping her arms around Finn in a gentle hug when they approached her.

“How are you feeling?”

“Nervous… there’s people out there that attended the last trial as the jury, now sitting in the audience..” She was glad it was a different jury this time, hopefully less blindsided by her race and species.

“Well, don’t focus on them, okay?” Adora sits down next to her, gently rubbing her back, “Just focus on getting your story out there and getting through this.”

Finn sits on the other side of Catra, their tail wrapping around her waist, “It’s gonna be okay, mama.”

Catra smiles slightly, “Thank you little one. I’ll be okay I just- I really hope this works.”

Glimmer walks into the room, “Okay! We have a few minutes, if you need to use the bathroom now is the time to do so.”

Finn slowly got to their feet, "Be right back." They hurry out of the room, making Adora and Glimmer giggles.

"Okay, so how this'll work is Judge Norwyn will go over the case, I'll question you and Finn, and then Prime will question you both."

Catra nods, taking a deep breath, "Okay, thanks Sparkles…" She quietly replied.

After a few more minutes, Finn returned just as Glimmer got to her feet, "Ready?"

"As I'll ever be…" Catra sighs, standing up as well.

"Okay. Finn, you're gonna sit at the table with Catra okay? Adora is gonna be in the first pew behind the table."

Finn nodded. They took Catra's hand, and the four walked out into the courtroom. Adora followed an officer to sit in the pews, while Catra and Finn took their seats with Glimmer at the defense table.

Unable to help herself, Catra glanced over at Prime, who was smirking, sitting calmly in his seat. He looked like he had already proven her guilty for a second time, like she had zero chance at

being exonerated. She shakily exhales, looking at the table until Judge Norwyn began speaking.

"This was a case that was tried and convicted ten years ago, but recently, evidence has been brought to light that may prove that the defendant is innocent of her charges. Each side will have time to do a brief opening statement, but since this case has been tried before, please try to keep it under ten minutes. Prosecutor, if you would start us off."

With a calm smile bordering on a smirk, he slowly rose from his seat, approaching the podium, "Thank you, Your Honor." He set his case file down, adjusting the microphone before continuing, "Now, while this case is open and shut, and frankly a retrial is a mockery to the justice system-"

"Prime." Judge Norwyn said once, his tone stern. A warning.

He held up his hand, before continuing, "Nevertheless, it is an open and shut case. Now bordering on twelve years ago police were called for a domestic disturbance to the first room on the third floor of the Spinner Apartment Complex. The caller was a neighbor, who said that they heard a lot of yelling, and before the call disconnected a single gunshot was heard in the background. When police arrived on scene, the landlord, Ms. Sharon Weaver was found dead at the scene, a bullet wound in her chest, the defendant was found with her five year old- child, the gun was on the floor, and was apprehended and arrested on sight. It really doesn't get anymore simple than that." He closed out, before taking his seat.

"Mrs. Arrow-Moon, if you would give the defense's statement?"

Smiling and nodding, "Thank you, Your Honor." She slowly stood, approaching the podium, "Now, as much as the prosecution would like to claim that this an 'open and shut' case, that is simply not true. This case has made a mockery of the justice system, but not in the way you may think. There is nasty corruption and racism involved. My client was treated very poorly, manhandled and forced into a confession by the Brightmoon Police Department. As I looked into the case I found that the gun was never swabbed for fingerprints, and on top of it all, she was not simply 'arrested' at the scene, her child was ripped out of her arms, and witnessed their mother be literally thrown to the ground, cuffed, and dragged out of the apartment complex like an animal. I have spent hours going through old files, and I have found the video of my client's interrogation, as well as the body-cam footage that was never shown in the original trial, that I plan to show today. With that evidence, as well as a witness, I believe the jury and public will see this case in a *very* different light, and the outcome will be just as different."

"Thank you, Mrs. Arrow-Moon. Now, if the prosecution will rise and present their evidence as well as question the defense."

Prime got to his feet again, "I would like to bring the defendant, Miss Catra Dr'iluth to the stand."

Catra felt her heart drop again. She knew it was coming, but she still didn't feel ready to face him again. She slowly got to her feet, her hands shaking as she walks towards the stand. The memory of the last time she did this came rushing back to the front of her mind. Her body wrapped in chains, the feeling of the rough

jumpsuit against her skin, the stares fueled by hatred. She slowly sat down on the stand.

“Before we begin, Miss Catra will you raise your right hand?” Norwyn asked.

Catra nodded, following his instruction, her right hand raising off the table.

“Repeat after me please. I do solemnly, sincerely, and truly declare and affirm that the testimony I am about to give will be the truth, the whole truth, and nothing but the truth.”

"I do solemnly, sincerely, and truly declare and affirm that the testimony I am about to give will be the truth, the whole truth, and nothing but the truth.” Catra repeated, before lowering her hand. Her ears folded against her head when Prime approached the podium.

“Let’s go back to the beginning. What led you to make the decision to move into that apartment complex?”

“It was the only thing I would technically afford for me and Finn.”

“Technically? Elaborate.”

"I worked three jobs to be able to afford the place. I worked at a gas station, Sweet Bee's Bistro as a waitress, and the Frightzone bar on weekends."

"And pray tell, how were you able to attend to three jobs without neglecting your infant child?"

"My best friends, Scorpia and Entrapta," She gestures to them. They were sitting by Adora, "would babysit for me. My main job was the bistro, and I worked at the gas station part-time."

"I understand that employment at the gas station and bar was terminated just five and four weeks before the shooting took place?"

"Yes."

"Can you explain the cause of termination?"

"Money went missing in the cash register at the gas station and I was blamed for it, so they fired me."

"And were you stealing money?"

“Of course not, but they didn’t bother to do a proper investigation.”

“And what about the bistro?”

“They weren’t making enough money to keep their doors open, so the job fell through.”

Prime nodded, “I also understand that Ms. Weaver had recently raised the rent?”

“Yes, which she knew I couldn’t afford when I had a toddler. I came home- that day, and the eviction notice was on my door.”

“An unfortunate situation, and she showed up that afternoon to give you the two weeks notice?”

“Yes.”

“And I presume the argument that followed is what led to the shooting.”

“Kinda, well, technically yes…”

“No further questions. I would like to question the witness, Finn Grayskull.”

Catra got to her feet, walking back to the table. She gave Finn’s hand a gentle squeeze before watching them walk over to the stand and sit down where she had just been.

Once Finn was sitting down and they adjusted the microphone, Judge Norwyn spoke up again, “Can you raise your right hand for me please Finn?” Finn nodded, lifting their right hand up, “Repeat after me, I do solemnly, sincerely, and truly declare and affirm that the testimony I am about to give will be the truth, the whole truth, and nothing but the truth.”

“I do solemnly, sincerely, and truly declare and affirm that the testimony I am about to give will be the truth, the whole truth, and nothing but the truth.” Finn repeated.

The judge nodded to Prime, signaling he was allowed to start questioning them.

“Now, Finn. Can you explain to me what happened that day from your perspective?”

Finn glanced at Catra and Adora before answering, “I remember mama coming home from work. Aunt Scorpia was with me. Catra talked to her for a few minutes before leaving. mama sat down with me to just hold me for a while, and that’s when Weaver

showed up. She told mama that she had two weeks to get out if she couldn't pay the rent that day. They started yelling at each other. I don't remember everything that was said."

"And what did you do?"

"I remembered mama had a gun in her nightstand. She always told me stay away from it, that it was only to be used in self-defense if you were in danger. Weaver always- scared me, and I didn't like how she was getting in mama's face and screaming at her, calling her names. So… I went and got it. I held it with both hands, and made my way back into the main room. I… I didn't mean to…" They suddenly tensed, the memories of that day slamming into them like a truck, "I remember the gun went off, and- and she collapsed..!" Tears ran down their face, and it took all of Scorpia, Entrapta, Adam, Teela, Bow, Adora, and Catra's willpower combined not to run up and pull them into the safety of their arms, "Mama pulled me into her arms, I dropped the gun she… she was fussing over my head," They point to the scar on their face, "The- the kickback from the weapon hit me, it's… I'm slowly losing my hearing in my left ear because of that day…"

Prime stared, clearing not seeing a confession coming from the kid of all people! He took a moment to process, before trying to regain his confidence, "How could you remember so many details from an event that happened to you ten years ago?"

"I've been in therapy for eight years now, I've processed everything and put the pieces together over time. It's hard to deny a truth like that when the evidence is on my face every time I look in the mirror."

Prime's silence was loud. It was clear he was unable to think of anything else to say except, "No further questions."

Glimmer stood up, "Is it okay if we take fifteen minutes before my questioning? I would like to give Finn a moment to calm down."

Judge Norwyn nodded, "Of course. A fifteen minute break will now commence." He said simply before tapping his gavel.

Catra immediately got to her feet and rushed over to Finn, wrapping her arms around them. She lifted them into her arms and carried them into the office off the side of the courtroom.

"I'm so proud of you, little one…" Catra whispered, dropping to her knees and just holding her child to her chest. Finn gripped onto her shoulder, whimpering as they quietly cried. Catra began to purr to try and calm them both down. The effect was fairly quick for Finn. They curled up, their tail wrapping around Catra as they slowly stopped crying.

Glimmer crouched down next to Catra, "You both did wonderful. I've never seen Prime be rendered speechless before."

"Really..?" Finn whispered, peaking up at Glimmer, who smiled and nodded.

“Mhm! We’re barely halfway done and I’m sure he’s already figured out he isn’t going to win this case.”

Catra rubbed Finn’s back, looking at Glimmer, “So… you’re gonna show the interrogation video and the body-cam…?”

Nodding, Glimmer, gave her arm a gentle squeeze, “I know it won’t be easy to watch, but it’ll be the cherry on top to proving your innocence, and it’ll help me start my case against the department. Once I’m done you won’t have to worry about money anymore.”

“That’s not really my concern, but thank you, Sparkles.” Catra smiles.

“Now, before I show the videos, I’m gonna question each of you too to get more details about everything for the jury.”

Catra nodded, “Right… Are you feeling okay, Finn…?”

“I’m okay mama…” Finn whispers, wiping their eyes, “What are you gonna ask me about?” They look at Glimmer.

“Mostly things concerning your medical history. I can’t really go into detail beforehand, okay?”

Nodding, Finn rested their head on Catra’s shoulder, “Okay…”

“Just take a deep breath, and once you’re both ready, we’ll go back inside.”

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Once everyone was seated back in the courtroom, Catra back on the stand, Glimmer was now standing at the podium, “Okay, I don’t have many questions for you about the day the incident happened, but I do have some about what followed after your arrest. Of course, I have video evidence to show the jury as well, but I think it’s important to hear your perspective beforehand.” She glanced over her notes before returning her gaze to Catra, “Can you tell me what happened when you were brought into the interrogation room?”

Catra took a deep breath, “They brought me into the room and sat me down at the table. They removed the cuffs from my right hand, but not on the left. They cuffed the free end to the table. I was alone for a few minutes before the interrogation officer came into the room. He told me that the evidence was all against me, and the easiest thing to do would simply be to write my confession.” She exhaled, fidgeting with the hem of her shirt as she continued, “They didn’t ask me a single question. They put the notepad on the table and left. I was in there for an hour.”

“Did you write the confession?”

“Yes. I- I didn’t have another choice. I knew if I didn’t they would find a way to force one out of me on the stand. Which, they did. Being on the stand was a nightmare. They ripped my entire life apart, made me seem like a ruthless monster that had just been waiting for the opportunity to take Weaver out, like I was a remorseless demon who didn’t deserve to live.”

“Do you have any remorse for what happened that day?”

“For Finn, for myself, but not for Weaver. I don’t think she necessarily deserved to be killed, but I can’t say I ever mourned her loss.”

Glimmer nodded, “Thank you, Catra. No more questions.” She said, before turning back towards the table, “I would now like to ask Finn a few questions.”

Just like before, Finn and Catra swapped places, and Finn adjusted the microphone, before looking at their aunt.

“Okay, Finn. I would like to talk a bit about your medical history. You already explained everything you knew about that day, but what about after? You said you were slowly losing your hearing. Can you please elaborate for the jury?”

“Yes. Ever since that day, my hearing as been slowly decreasing in my left ear. On my last visit, my doctor said I’m down to about

45% hearing left. Within the next year, I'll have to have a hearing aid for that side."

"And what about the scar? Does it ever cause you pain?"

They shook their head, "Not really. It used to, but after so many years it's just kinda- there."

"And how has the rest of the situation affected you? I understand you didn't really become aware of Catra until after she was released from prison and reached out to your social worker."

"It's- it's been hard. For as long as I can remember, I've had dreams, almost vision-like, of mama. I could never quite remember her face, but I would recall memories of her holding me or taking me for a walk to the park. And- her laugh. I remembered her voice. She used to sing me lullabies every night." Catra listened intently to her child's testimony. Her eyes glossed over, "I never brought it up to mom." They point to Adora for the jury's sake, "Because she had always been reserved about anything to do with me before she adopted me. It wasn't until I found the letters that I understood better."

Catra's ears perked up, eyes widening. They had read the letters?

"The letters?" Glimmer asked.

Finn nodded, "Mama sent me- I dunno hundreds of letters over the years. Mom never let me have them. She had them all in a box on the top shelf in her office. But- after I learned some of what was going on, and mom wouldn't tell me, I- I snuck into her office and I found them. I read every single one of them. It- it was hard to read them, to hear about how much my mama loved me and I barely remembered her face. I don't want to talk about what was in the letters. It's mine. When I saw her again for the first time I… it was like everything just came back to me. I knew *who* she was, who she was to *me.* We talked for a long time, and I started to remember more and more."

"And how are you doing now? Now that you have her back."

"My family feels- complete. I'm happier, and I don't have nightmares anymore."

With a smile, Glimmer nodded, motioning behind her, "No more questions, you can sit down now."

Once Finn was back in their seat, the judge returned his attention to Glimmer, "I understand you've entered two videos into evidence?"

"Yes. I would like to present the jury with both the body-cam and the interrogation footage to backup my client's testimony. It is vital evidence that was not presented in the original trial."

Nodding, Norwyn motioned to the laptop that was set up near the screen hanging on the wall. Glimmer approached, opening the file and pulling the body-cam footage up on the screen. She turned up the volume and pressed play.

The video started with two officers climbing the stairs of the apartment complex, talking over the radio.

"The call was about domestic violence?"

"Be advised officers the caller said they heard a gunshot so be on the lookout for a possible 10-54. An ambulance is en route."

"Advised, thank you dispatch." The officer replied. They approached the door, pushing it open. The camera showed Catra sitting against the back of the couch and the wall, cradling a five-year-old five Finn curled up and crying in her arms.

The officers immediately drew their weapons on Catra, despite Finn still easily being within range. They started yelling at her to get down and put her hands behind her back.

Catra had to look away as the officers in the video ripped Finn out of her arms and shoved to the side while she was roughly shoved to the ground and her wrists were cuffed behind her. One of the officers requested CPS from dispatch, and Catra was hauled out of the apartment, Finn's cries for her fading into the background. She was relieved when Glimmer cut the video off.

Finn wrapped their tail around Catra's, both of them actively fighting not to cry again.

Glimmer let the jury process what they'd seen for a moment while she found and pulled up the file with the interrogation footage, "Next, I'm going to show you the footage that was buried alongside the body-cam footage; the interrogation video." She clicked the play button.

The video opened to Catra being brought into the small room. She was still quietly crying, her cheeks damp with tears. She was sat down in a chair after one cuff was removed from her wrist and cuffed to the table. The officers then stepped out of the room and closed the door. Glimmer had sped the footage along to when the interrogator walked into the room, a pen and notepad in hand, "Afternoon." He said simply, sitting down. Catra didn't respond, staring down at the table, "The evidence is quite stacked against you. I would suggest you make this easy for everyone and simply write down your confession." With that, he got to his feet and left the room. The video started speeding up again as Catra eventually looked up and started writing.

As it sped through it, Glimmer addressed the jury, "What is being sped up is an hour of my client being left alone in that room to write a confession. No questions were asked, her rights were never read. That alone is enough to throw this case out completely."

She lets the rest of the video play out, though it was simply officers returning and placing her under arrest.

Glimmer couldn’t help but glance over at Prime, who looked like he’d rather be anywhere but in this courtroom, “Alone, these videos prove the direct corruption and racism my client faced within our justice system, but after hearing about what Finn also went through, and how the case as a whole was handled, it is easy to see that this case was a tragic accident, and that my client should be exonerated of any and all charges. Thank you, Your Honor.”

Judge Norwyn nodded, letting Glimmer sit down before turning his attention to Prime, “Would the prosecution like to make a closing statement?”

“…No, Your Honor.”

“In that case, the jury is dismissed to discuss the case.” Norwyn replied before tapping his gavel.

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When the jury returned, Catra, Glimmer, and Prime all stood for the reading of the verdict. Judge Norwyn went through the motions of confirming that each juror was in agreement with the verdict about to be read. After all jurors confirmed they were all in agreement, the first juror stood, holding the verdict sheet in hand.

“We the jury find the defendant on count one of first degree murder, not guilty.”

The words echoed through her ears, and Catra all but collapsed into her seat, tears running down her face as relief coursed through her body. She faintly heard the other few bogus charges be read out, but only the words ‘not guilty’ stuck, ringing through her ears.

Once the full verdict was read, Judge Norwyn smiled, looking at Catra, who had barely been able to collect herself, her hands shaking and tears running down her face as Finn hugged her tightly, “On that note, Catra Dr’iluth, you are hereby dismissed of all charges, and any note of conviction will be wiped clean of your record. You are free to go.” He tapped his gavel.

Catra couldn’t find herself able to fully relax and take a moment to calm down until Finn and Glimmer led her into the latter’s office down the hallway. She gasped, practically falling into Adora’s arms when the blonde wrapped her arms around her, “You did it…” She smiled. She kept one arm around her, the other going around Finn, “I’m so proud of both of you. You did so well.”

“T-Thank you…”

“Thanks, mom…”

“I’m just- so glad it’s over…” Catra sighed, wiping her eyes and resting her head on Adora’s shoulder.

“Well, to celebrate, we’re all going to take you out to eat at that sushi restaurant you and Finn love so much.”

Finn smiled, their tail starting to sway at the idea.

Catra smiled too, “Thanks… that sounds really nice right now. I just want to be as far away from this place as possible.”

“Understandable. Let’s go then.” Adora chuckles, “Ready Glimmer?”

“Oooh yeah. I’m ready to relax for at least one night before I start drafting my case against the department.”

Nodding, Adora started guiding Finn and Catra out of the room, ready to join the others in a much deserved celebration dinner.

Chapter End Notes

Hhhhhhhhhh only one chapter left!!

Testing the Waters

Chapter Summary

"It's here!"

"It is?" Catra smiled, leaning over Adora's shoulder.

"What is?" Finn asked, ears perking up in interest.

The women exchanged looks before smiling.

Chapter Notes

The end of Blindsided has arrived! Ahhhhh!

I wanted to give a cute ending and I really hope you enjoy it!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

In the months since the retrial, since Catra's exoneration, she had started spending more and more time at Adora's apartment. They had sent in for a paternity test a month ago, and she knew the results would be in today. The thought made Catra smile as she ran down the sidewalk. She'd taken to going on daily runs every afternoon around the block. She was approaching the parking lot to the apartment complex when she noticed a familiar pickup truck pulling in. She smiled, waving at Adora and Finn. She ran onto the sidewalk that circled the building, waiting on the curb near the door where Adora always parked.

"How was your run?" Adora asked after she parked and got out of the vehicle.

"Good." She smiled, "Did you have a good day, Finn?"

The teen nodded, though was quiet. Two weeks ago they had made the decision to have the hearing aid implanted in their ear. A week ago, the procedure had been done. It wasn't really noticeable, but it was clear Finn still hated having to get it. Catra understood, more so than Adora did. Hearing was a major part of a magicat, and she knew it had been hard for them to admit defeat and get the implant. Sighing, she walked over and wrapped an arm around their shoulders. Finn leaned into the hold.

"You know I'm proud of you, right? So is Adora."

Finn nodded, "Thank you…" They quietly replied, allowing their mother to guide them towards the building. They stopped when Adora walked over to the wall of mail boxes. She flipped through her keys until she found the one she was looking for. With a quiet hum she unlocked her box and pulled out the small stack of envelopes. They were all white, except for one. It was yellow, and was a little bigger than the others. Adora smiled, and pulled that one of the front.

"It's here!"

"It is?" Catra smiled, leaning over Adora's shoulder.

"What is?" Finn asked, ears perking up in interest.

The women exchanged looks before smiling, “Let’s go inside first.” Adora said, and the three made their way into the building.

Once inside and Catra and Adora had taken their shoes off, they sat on the couch with Finn between them. Finn couldn’t help but be a little worried and tense when Adora discarded the other envelopes on the coffee table, holding the yellow one in her lap, “Okay. So Finn, remember that- comment you made about looking like a perfect mix between me and Adora?” Finn slowly nodded, “Well, a long time ago, I was at a bar, and I met someone who looked a lot like Adam, except it wasn’t…”

Finn’s eyes widened as they realized what Catra was implying, “Whoa whoa whoa! Hold on! Are you saying I’m… That I’m actually ..?” They looked at Adora, who blushed.

“That’s why Catra and I decided to send for a paternity test to confirm.”

“And that… that’s the… results?” Finn pointed at the yellow envelope. Adora nodded.

“Before we open them though, no matter what it says, we want you to know that neither of us are going anywhere. We’re both your moms. No matter what, okay?” Catra explained, taking and squeezing Finn’s hand.

Finn nodded, “Can… can I open it?”

Adora smiled, handing them the envelope, “Sure, sweetie.”

Slowly, the teen took the envelope into their hands. They slowly slid their claw across the top to open it, pulling the folded document out, holding it in their hands. They took a deep breath and glancing between their mothers before unfolding the document. The page had a chart with a bunch of DNA stuff on it, but at the bottom, it had a simple message.

Birth Parent: Catra Dr’iluth

Child: Finn Dr’iluth (adoptive last name- Grayskull)

The conclusion serves to show that the likelihood of Adora Grayskull is the opposing parent to Finn Dr’iluth/Grayskull is 99.99%.

“What does that mean?” Finn looked up at the women, who chuckled.

“It means, that we’re both your biological parents. They never give a hundred percent on these, but that still confirms it.”

Catra couldn’t help but laugh, relief flooding her as she hugged Finn to her chest, feeling Adora hug them both seconds later, “I’m so relieved…”

“Why?” Finn asked through the forming tears.

“I was so scared Adam had been an idiot that night…”

Adora laughed, “Adam?! You *really* thought-” One look from Catra made it clear she was serious, that she had been genuinely concerned about the possibility, “Well, he’s not, and we don’t have to worry about that.” She squeezed Catra’s shoulder.

“So… are you two gonna like- date and get married?”

“Finn..!” both women blushed, but the accusation did hold merit, whether they were ready to admit it or not. Multiple times in the past couple of months, Catra had snuck into Adora’s room, the two feeling like teenagers again as they cuddled together and whispered about- whatever. They had talked about dating a few times, just to see where it went, but they wanted Finn’s approval and out of curiosity- to see what the test said.

“What? Your both my moms, and mama is around all the time anyway. I mean- do you like each other?”

“Well- I..”

“Uhm…”

Rolling their eyes, Finn got to their feet, “Okay, I’m going to my room so you two can stop acting like kittens.”

“Finn!” Catra blushed, watching her child giggle and run down the hallway. The sound of their door closing behind them echoed down the hallway a few seconds later, leaving the two flushed women on the couch.

The two looked at each other, blushing when they made eye contact, “Well, should we…?”

Adora smiled, “We already talked about it a few weeks ago… I wouldn’t be opposed. I do- I really do like you, Catra. Ever since I met you- again; I… I don’t know how to explain it…”

Catra gently reached up and cupped Adora’s cheek, smiling warmly at her, “I like you too, Adora…”

Blushing, Adora rested her hand over Catra’s, giving it a gentle squeeze, “Well… I can call Adam over and- we could go out to dinner?”

“Well, I certainly don’t trust you cooking, so I *suppose* we could..” Catra smirked, giggling when Adora pouted at her.

“Catra…”

“Hey, I’ve seen first hand experience of you *trying* to cook!” Catra laughed, squeaking when Adora pulled her into her arms.

“Well then, how does sushi sound?” Adora suggested, a knowing smile on her face when Catra’s tail started swaying, “Looks like that’s a yes?”

“Yes.” Catra blushed, “And we can bring some home for Finn.”

“Of course.”

⚔

“You look like you’re deep in thought.” Adora’s voice cut through the loud thoughts in Catra’s mind. She looked up from her plate, smiling at the blonde.

“I’m just- happy. Out of everything I expected when I was released this- being with my baby, finding someone who actually cares about me, it’s… everything I never knew I wanted. Needed..”

Smiling, Adora reached across the table, gently grasping Catra's hand in her own and squeezing it lightly, "You deserve it. You deserve to be happy, and I'm overjoyed to be apart of that happiness."

Blushing, Catra simply nodding, "Thank you…"

The waitress approached, setting a bag with a to go box inside on their table, "Here's your to go order."

"Thank you." Adora smiled, and the waitress stepped away, "Well, are we ready?"

Catra nodded, leaving a ten on the table before grabbing the bag and the two walked out of the restaurant. The sun had just set, leaving a warm glow over the building and parking lot. Adora gently wrapped her arm around Catra, who giggled and leaned into her hold, "What are you doing?"

"I just like holding you.." Adora smiles, "And, if you don't mind, I…" She slowly slides her hand up Catra's arm to cup her cheek, "Catra I… I really like you I…"

Catra looked up at Adora, eyes widening and face turning red when she realized what her intentions were. She smiled, her tail starting to sway, "I really like you too…" She flushed when Adora brushed her bangs out of her face. The two stared at each other, the space between them slowly drifting away, until the wavering

light from the sunset between them disappeared as their lips joined together. The kiss was electric, sending waves through both women.

When they pulled apart, they simply stared at the other for a few moments, smiling like idiots, “We should get home.” Catra giggled, “We can cuddle and watch a movie?”

“Sounds perfect.”

Chapter End Notes

I can't wait to hear what you think! I'm going to spend a lot of April finishing up my Big Bang fic for 2025. I've been cooking something for it since like- November of 2024? LOL, I can't remember exactly when I started it, but I'm excited to share! Lookout for that in May! :)

I'm *hoping* to post at least one more Blonde in My Arms chapter before May, but I have a lot going on so we shall see. It'll probably be after the Big Bang as well, but I will be posting a brand new AU kinda soon... <3

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!